NO. 140 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 22 OCTOBER 2026



NO AIRCRAFT NUMBER, NO BASE, AND A REFUELLING CLAUSE THAT CUTS THE OTHER WAY (P3)

THE WORLD

Britain sends Typhoons to defend Saudi airspace, and rules out striking the Houthis

Twelve Desks · One World

THE ATELIER

A £280 hanger and a S$1.11 hanger span the same 430 millimetres

THE RABBIT HOLE

Retrocomputing's busiest room is a Discord about a $750 video scaler

Source: Cpl Nathan Edwards / UK Ministry of Defence, OGL v3.0, via Wikimedia Commons — two RAF Typhoon FGR4 aircraft on an Operation Shader sortie over the Middle East, photographed 13 November 2024. A library image, opened and examined by this desk before captioning: it is not a photograph of this week's deployment, and no tanker aircraft is in frame. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 140

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THE SPINE — THE READING. A number is not the thing it counts. An export boom made of boat hulls, a housing fall smaller than its own error bar, gold called a record while below its own average, and a police force that can count everyone but the person giving orders.

FROM THE DESK

"If names be not correct, language is not in accordance with the truth of things."

Confucius, *Analects*, Book XIII, Chapter 3, in James Legge's translation[1]

Four desks today turn on a word doing work a number should. London calls a mission defensive and refuels the offensive one (p3); Japan's police had to invent a noun for a crime with no organisation (p21); and a hanger carries the name of the shop, not the workshop (p6).

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.81%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year[2]	5.13%	▲ 1bp
VWRA	$192.28	▲ 0.48%
Global agg	$5.77	▲ 0.19%
DXY	101.71	0.00%
USD/SGD	1.2773	▲ 0.01%
Brent	$109.73	▲ 0.86%
Gold	$4,140.83	▲ 0.39%
Bitcoin	$84,638	▲ 2.10%

The Straits Times Index closed **5,404.02** on Tuesday and **5,437.99** on Wednesday, up 0.63 per cent (**p14**). Every level read at source, instrument by instrument. Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · THURSDAY

No. 136 held September's export print, unread at source for three issues. **EnterpriseSG's listing page still returns 500** — but the release is up in its media library: **68.4 per cent**, with the agency's own "lumpy" caveat (p5).

No. 139 printed that three of ten NEA notices repeated 2015 names. The three are now named (p5).

No. 139 held MOFCOM's AI export thresholds when the ministry returned 503. The announcement is readable now, and the answer is that **there are no thresholds** — only categories, with open weights carved out (p7).

No. 138's Next Descents chips offered violin making, sheepdog trialling and retrocomputing restoration. With no editor note and no reader vote since the last build, the third is today's descent (p15).

SOURCES 1 Confucius, *Analects*, Book XIII, Chapter 3, verses 4–7, in James Legge's translation (Legge, *Confucian Analects, The Great Learning, and The Doctrine of the Mean*, pp. 263–264). **The gloss beneath the quotation is this desk's reading of this issue, not of the passage.** 2 Levels at Wednesday 21 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on **p14**; **Treasury yields read from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file**, equities, commodities and crosses from reference quotes with gold, Brent and bitcoin independently corroborated at a second source apiece.

THE WORLD · SAUDI ARABIA & THE HOUTHIS

Britain sends Typhoons to defend Saudi airspace, ruling out Houthi strikes

Wes Streeting's ministry published the order on 20 October, naming no aircraft number and no base. Riyadh's main airport has been struck twenty times this month.

The British **Ministry of Defence** published an operational update on **Tuesday 20 October** committing **RAF Typhoon** fighters to defensive counter-air missions over Saudi Arabia, with one **A400M** moving materiel inside the kingdom. The release gives neither an aircraft count nor a base.[1]

The limit is written into the same page: the aircraft **"will not conduct offensive strikes against the Houthis"**. Defence Secretary **Wes Streeting** called the attacks on Saudi Arabia **"absolutely despicable"**.[1]

One clause complicates the word. The same release extends British **air-to-air refuelling** for Saudi operations **"including against Houthi military targets in Yemen"**. The defensive label attaches to the aircraft, not to every sortie the tankers keep aloft.[1]

The pressure behind it is measurable. Riyadh's international airport has been targeted **twenty times since the start of October**. The casualties are not reconciled: one account gives **13 dead and over 300 injured** for the **10 October** strike on King Khalid International, another **19 dead** across Riyadh and Abha for the month, both citing **Turki al-Maliki**. Both are printed rather than averaged.[2][3]

Three other capitals moved the same week. **Emmanuel Macron** stopped unannounced in Riyadh on **21 October**, leaving with Saudi diesel "for as many months as necessary". **Türkiye** sent the **Makkah Joint Defense Agreement**, signed with Riyadh and Pakistan on **7 August**, to its parliament. Only **Egypt** drew a line: **Abdel Fattah El-Sisi** confined Egyptian help to Saudi soil and ruled out attacking Yemen.[4][5][6][9]

295,000t

GULF DIESEL A MONTH NOW COMMITTED TO FRANCE — SAUDI, EMIRATI AND BAHRAINI VOLUMES TOGETHER, JUST OVER A TENTH OF FRENCH CONSUMPTION[4]

LONDON — MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

States the limit before anyone asks: the Typhoons **"will not conduct offensive strikes"**. Written to be quoted against a future accusation — and burying the refuelling clause.[1]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Files it as imperial continuity rather than news: **"the latest chapter in a military relationship older than the kingdom itself"** — Britain armed Ibn Saud by treaty in **1915**, seventeen years before the kingdom existed.[3][7]

TEHRAN — PRESS TV

Will not print the word Houthi. The attacks are by **"the Yemeni Armed Forces"**, whose spokesman **Yahya Saree** calls the coalition's drone claims **"baseless and unsubstantiated"**. The vocabulary is the argument.[8]

THE CHATTER · THE ANALYSTS WHO THINK RIYADH ASKED FOR LESS

Nawaf Obaid, King's College London, is broadly supportive — **"militarily valuable and politically significant"** — and still undercuts the framing: Saudi Arabia **"does not need foreign assistance to conduct air strikes"**, only defensive cover.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · DEFENSIVE IS NOT A LABEL THE OTHER SIDE ACCEPTS

Urban Coningham of RUSI says the Houthis may read British refuelling of Saudi jets as **offensive** and treat British forces as targets, **Cyprus included**. **Burcu Ozcelik** doubts the missions move **"the dial"** at all, Saudi interceptor stocks being stretched already.[3]

What would settle it is the number the release withholds. Two aircraft from **Akrotiri** is a gesture; a squadron in the kingdom is a war.

SOURCES 1 **The UK Ministry of Defence's own operational update of 20 October 2026, read at source on gov.uk**, for the Typhoon and A400M commitment, the air-to-air refuelling extension and its "including against Houthi military targets in Yemen" wording, the "defensive role" limit and the Streeting quotation. **It gives no aircraft number and no basing location; neither is estimated here.** 2 Gulf News (Dubai), 21 October 2026, read at source, for the twenty strikes on Riyadh's airport since 1 October, and as the second, independently-owned outlet carrying the ministry's own lines. 3 Al Jazeera, 21 October 2026, read at source, for the competing casualty scopes attributed to Turki al-Maliki and for every analyst quotation (Ozcelik and Coningham of RUSI, Obaid of King's College London). 4 Al Jazeera, same date, for Macron's Riyadh stop and the diesel total. 5 Arab News for Türkiye's submission of the Makkah pact to parliament. 6 Anadolu Agency for the Jordan–Saudi protocol. 7 Al Jazeera on the Darin and Al-Yamamah history. 8 Press TV, 21 October, for Saree. 9 Xinhua, 21 October, for El-Sisi. **Reuters, the BBC, AP, the Guardian, Sky and CNBC all refused this desk, so no wire or broadsheet line appears in this issue that was not read at its publisher.**

THE WORLD · MALAYSIA

Malaysia deregisters Perikatan Nasional eleven days before Melaka nominations

The complaint that killed the coalition was filed by Bersatu, one of its own parties. Nominations fall on 31 October, polling on 14 November.

Malaysia's **Registrar of Societies** announced on **Tuesday 20 October** that it had cancelled the registration of **Perikatan Nasional**, the country's main opposition coalition, under **subparagraph 13(1)(c)(iv) of the Societies Act 1966**. The national news agency timestamped the statement at **10.18am**.[1]

The chain began inside the coalition. **Bersatu**, a Perikatan component, complained that it had been excluded from a Supreme Council meeting on **16 July**, an alleged breach of **Clause 7.1** of Perikatan's own constitution. The registrar served a show-cause notice on **22 September**, received the coalition's explanation on **12 October**, and cancelled eight days later: **"the reasons given did not refute the grounds for deregistration"**.[12] Secretary-general **Takiyuddin Hassan** said the Act allows an appeal to the minister **within 30 days**. The High Court has granted leave for judicial review but **refused an interim stay**; Perikatan accuses the registrar of acting **"mala fide"**.[34] What dies is the banner, not the parties. **PAS** and Bersatu remain registered, and Takiyuddin expects Perikatan to contest Melaka under a component logo.[3]

13(1)(c)(iv)

THE SUBPARAGRAPH OF THE SOCIETIES ACT 1966 UNDER WHICH A COALITION OF REGISTERED PARTIES CEASED TO EXIST[1]

THE CHATTER · THE COMPLAINT CAME FROM INSIDE THE COALITION

Bersatu secretary-general **Azmin Ali** read the ruling as vindication — proof, he said, that the PAS-held leadership had breached both the Act and Perikatan's constitution. An opposition party welcomed the dissolution of its own alliance eleven days before nomination day.[14]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE ACADEMICS SAY IT CHANGES LITTLE

Lau Zhe Wei of the International Islamic University Malaysia: **"PAS remains the coalition's main source of electoral support"**, and **"using the PAS logo is the simplest way to win more seats"**. **Liew Wui Chern** expects the consequence to be **"political rather than legal"**. Only **Mohammad Tawfik Yaakub** goes further: **"a serious organisational setback"** — a setback, not an execution.[5]

ALSO THIS WEEK

Quebec installs a minister for leaving Canada. Days after Alberta voted three to one to stay, **Paul St-Pierre Plamondon** was sworn in, the Parti Québécois holding **59 of 127 seats** on **28 per cent** of the vote. A minister holds the independence file; the referendum waits until the US president leaves office in **2029**. Single-sourced.[6]

One of eight compromised signing keys was the number 4. Private keys for eight **eMudhra** intermediate certificates leaked; Mozilla was notified at **20:06 UTC on 17 October**. **Scott Helme** found one key was the integer **4**; others were 56, 115, 66, 155 and 230. eMudhra claims over **60 million** certificates issued.[8]

UK inflation, a Mars moon, a market struck. UK annual CPI was **3.5 per cent** in September, published **21 October**.[9] **JAXA**'s **MMX** probe left Tanegashima at **04:41:03 JST on 20 October**, separating **71 minutes** later.[7] In **Abyei**, the toll from a drone strike on **Amiet Market** reached **220 dead**; South Sudan blames Sudan's army.[10]

Brent moved between **$97 and $112** across the month, and the strait is still the price-setter (p14).[11]

SOURCES 1 **Bernama, Malaysia's national news agency, read at source**, reproducing the Registrar of Societies' statement of 20 October 2026 with its statutory citation, the 10.18am timestamp and the full 16 July – 20 October chain, and for Azmin Ali's response. **The registrar publishes no fetchable page of its own; this is the statement as the agency carried it, not a document read at the regulator.** 2 The Star, 20 October, read at source, for the "did not refute the grounds" wording. 3 Free Malaysia Today, 20 October, for Takiyuddin Hassan's remarks and the 30-day appeal. 4 Malaysiakini, 20 October, for the grant of leave for judicial review, the refusal of an interim stay and the "mala fide" accusation. **A stay hearing was reported as listed for about 22 October; its outcome was unknown when this page closed and could reverse the deregistration.** 5 The Star, 21 October, for all three academic assessments and the 31 October nomination and 14 November polling dates. 6 The Globe and Mail for the Quebec cabinet and seat shares. **Single-sourced; the swearing-in date is stated outright nowhere this desk could read.** 7 **JAXA's own English press pages** for the launch and separation times. 8 The Register, 20 October, for the eMudhra key compromise. 9 **The Office for National Statistics' own pages** for September's 3.5 per cent. 10 Sudans Post, 20 October, for the Amiet Market toll. **Single-sourced.** 11 Associated Press copy via Transport Topics for the month's $97–$112 Brent range.

SINGAPORE · THE NATIONAL WAGES COUNCIL

National Wages Council raises its low-wage ask to 6–8 per cent

The Government accepted the guidelines on 19 October. Just over a quarter of employers met last year's lower recommendation, the manpower ministry says.

The Government accepted the **National Wages Council**'s 2026/2027 guidelines on **Monday 19 October**. For employees earning up to **$2,800** a month — about the **20th percentile** of full-time resident wages — firms that have done well should pay **at the higher end of 6.0 to 8.0 per cent, or at least $135 to $170, whichever is higher**, from **1 December**.[1]

The council also invented an employer. Para 19 records that it **"created a new category"** for firms that have not done well **and are unprofitable**. Even they are told to pay **at least $120** more a month: a loss-making Singapore company now has a recommended pay rise.[1]

The backdrop is strong and uneven. The economy grew **5.4 per cent** year on year in the third quarter, for **6.0** across three quarters; productivity rose **3.8 per cent** and unit labour cost **fell 0.8**. But the **chemicals cluster** contracted, which the council attributes to the Middle East conflict, and food-and-beverage value added shrank.[1]

The export number arrived the same week and needs the same care. September **non-oil domestic exports rose 68.4 per cent** year on year, after 46.1 in August, electronics up **107.6**. EnterpriseSG attributes it primarily to **"lumpy"** exports of ship and boat structures — **S$3.7bn**, the largest single contributor. Strip the hulls and the artificial-intelligence demand is still there; the 68.4 is not a clean reading of it.[2][2]

6.0–8.0%

RECOMMENDED RISE FOR WORKERS ON UP TO $2,800 A MONTH — THE WIDEST BAND SINCE 2021[1][3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Ten haze notices, and three familiar names. NEA served notices on three more Indonesian firms over Kalimantan fires on **19 October**, after seven on the 16th. **PT Bumi Andalas Permai, PT Bumi Mekar Hijau and PT SBA Wood Industries were served in 2015 too.** A notice is not a finding of guilt, and no prosecution has ever been completed.[4]

A haze rulebook published as the haze lifted. MOM's guidance of **20 October** bands one-hour PM2.5: above **150µg/m³** healthy staff avoid strenuous outdoor work. At **05:00 on 22 October** every region read Band 1, against a central peak of **229** on the 16th. The release names no penalty.[5][6]

THE CHATTER · LABOUR WANTS THE HOURS, NOT JUST THE MONEY

NTUC president **K Thanaletchimi** backed the guidelines and pressed employers on something they do not cost: **protected training time**, so workers are not upgrading themselves out of their own evenings.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE MINISTRY'S OWN NUMBER UNDERCUTS THE HEADLINE

Manpower permanent secretary **Stanley Loh** says **just over a quarter** of employers met last year's recommendations, against an adoption rate above **70 per cent** before the guidelines were broadened in 2021. More than **60 per cent** of those who fell short still raised wages, by less. Loh's framing is the point: the Progressive Wage Model and Local Qualifying Salary **set mandatory requirements, while the guidelines are recommendations** — and some workers are caught by neither.[3]

The council raised its ask to the highest band since 2021 at the moment it is least often met. The mandatory floors do the work; the guidelines do the talking.

SOURCES 1 **The Ministry of Manpower's release of 19 October 2026 and the 2026/2027 NWC Guidelines themselves, the PDF read as text** — for the 6.0–8.0 per cent bands and their dollar floors, the $2,800 threshold and its 20th-percentile footnote, the new fourth category at para 19, and the GDP, productivity, unit-labour-cost, chemicals and F&B passages. 2 **EnterpriseSG's monthly trade report for September 2026 (MR 046/26), the PDF read at source**, for 68.4 per cent, the 46.1 August comparison, electronics at 107.6, the S$3.7bn ship-and-boat contribution and the agency's own "lumpy" characterisation. **Its media-centre listing page has returned HTTP 500 for four consecutive issues; the release PDF in its media library is up.** 3 Mothership, 19 October, read at source, for Stanley Loh's adoption figures and framing, and K Thanaletchimi's remarks. 4 Mothership and New Straits Times/Bernama, 19 October, for the three further notices, the seven of 16 October and the three firms also served in 2015. **NEA's own newsroom renders empty to this desk and the release could not be read at the agency.** 5 **MOM's own guidance release of 20 October**, for the PM2.5 bands and the absence of any stated penalty. 6 **Singapore's own real-time PM2.5 and PSI feeds on data.gov.sg**, timestamped 05:00 on 22 October 2026. 7 **The Ministry of Transport's own transcript of Jeffrey Siow's remarks. Single-sourced; it states no cost figures and none are estimated.**

THE ATELIER · SUIT & SHIRT HANGERS

Nakata's £280 hanger spans the same 430mm as IKEA's S$1.11 one

Both are 430 millimetres across. Nakata's shoulder is 60 millimetres thick against IKEA's 14, is carved from one jointless block, and takes 24 weeks.

One dimension does the work here, and it is not the width. It is the **flare** — the thickness of the shoulder at its widest point, which holds a canvassed jacket's line instead of folding it. **IKEA's BUMERANG** is 43cm wide and **14mm** thick at **S$1.11**.[6] **Butler Luxury's Tailor Made®** is **66.7mm** at **US$36**, in Grade A German beech. **Nakata's NH-2**, hand-carved from one jointless block, is **60mm**, **£280**, and takes **24 weeks**. The best-known luxury hanger in English, **The Hanger Project**'s at **US$34.95**, is **stained birch**.[123]

The white-label truth is not the one the forums half-remember. On **7 July 2006** a Styleforum member opened a group buy: **"I actually tracked down... the manufacturer of Oxxford's hangers, Beverly Hanger Company" — 200-piece minimum, about US$11** each. The member was **Kirby Allison**. A 2010 review records the hangers arriving with a **Beverly Hangers imprint**, made in China.[42]

Nobody hides it: **Arterton** of London prints **"Made in Japan by Nakata for Arterton"** on its label. And the cedar sold on moths does not repel them — **Blake Layton**, entomologist at **Mississippi State**: **"studies show that cedar does not really repel clothes moths"**.[15]

66.7mm

BUTLER'S SHOULDER FLARE, AGAINST IKEA'S 14MM AND THE £280 GRAIL'S 60MM[12]

WHAT IT COSTS LANDED

Shipping is the hidden cost. Butler's own checkout quotes Singapore **US$135.98** on **US$180** of hangers — carriage at **76 per cent** of goods. Arterton is the sensible route: three Nakata at **£155 plus £34**, about **S$110 landed**. With humidity averaging **82 per cent**, a hanger's tropical job is **spacing, not scent**.[78]

THE CHATTER · THE FORUMS SPLIT ON WOOD AGAINST SHAPE

Styleforum, June 2013. **johnnynorman3**: **"I like the wood on the Butler better but the shape on the HP seem superior to me"**. **elstinnett** decided on fit instead: **"The ability to choose widths is the exact reason that I went with HP hangers"**.[9]

THE SCEPTIC · RETURNS STOP AT ABOUT FIFTY DOLLARS

A US$36 hanger measurably buys three things a US$12 one does not: **flare**, **mass**, and a hook engineered against pull-out. It stops there. Past it you buy grain (**rosewood, US$98**), the removal of a joint (**£280**) or lacquer art (**£1,460**) — and the grail's shoulder is **thinner** than the mid-tier Butler's. On The Fedora Lounge, **sirkris** builds a 50mm flare from pipe insulation at **£1.50**. He is right about the physics, and has not built something still 50mm in thirty years.[92]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Upholstered sofas & armchairs — eight-way hand-tied springs, and the frame nobody sees.

Carbon-steel frying pans — the thin forged pan the French and Japanese houses still hammer.

Mosquito nets & bed canopies — the tropical object with a published standard behind it.

SOURCES 1 **Butler Luxury's own product, FAQ and About Us pages, read at source**, for the Tailor Made® 2⅝-inch shoulder and the US$29/36/38 steps, Grade A German beech and African rosewood, the 25lb rated load and the "global luxury design manufacturer" passage. 2 **KirbyAllison.com's own product pages, read at source**, for US$34.95 and the four widths, the 2.5-inch flare, the birch/maple/beech split by finish, the NH-2 at US$385 with its 24-week wait, the 200-unit custom programme, the US$98 rosewood and the urushi tier. 3 **Arterton London's own pages, read at source**, for "Made in Japan by Nakata for Arterton", the £44 Signature and the £155 AUT-05 set; The Armoury's artisan page for Nakata's 1946 founding in Hyogo. **Nakata's own site returned HTTP 500 on every variant tried, so the maker is priced entirely through its named retail partners.** 4 Styleforum's "Commissioning custom wooden hangers" thread of July 2006, read at source, for Kirby Allison's own words naming Beverly Hanger Company as Oxxford's manufacturer, the 200-piece minimum and the US$11–12 price; Gentleman's Gazette, 2010 and 2012, for the Beverly imprint, the Chinese manufacture and the weighed 17-ounce and 10.5-ounce figures. **This desk found no source supporting the widely-repeated claim that Butler manufactures for The Hanger Project; it is not printed here.** 5 **Mississippi State University Extension,** *Bug-Wise* **No. 1, 22 February 2005, by entomologist Blake Layton, PDF read at source.** 6 **IKEA Singapore's own BUMERANG page** for S$8.90 for eight, 43cm and 14mm; Mainetti's own pages for the 1961 founding, the 45-plus countries and both cedar prices. 7 **Shipping quotes from Butler's and Arterton's own checkout endpoints for a Singapore address.** 8 **The Meteorological Service Singapore** for the 82 per cent mean humidity and the **Canadian Conservation Institute** for mould "strongly active above 85%". 9 Styleforum (2013) and The Fedora Lounge, read at source, quoted under posted handles. **Permanent Style was behind a challenge page and is not quoted.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE ANTHROPIC PROSPECTUS

Draft filing puts Anthropic's half-year loss at US$80.7bn on US$16.3bn revenue

Roughly US$72bn of that loss is non-cash, booked because the company grew more valuable. A listing is targeted for as soon as November.

A draft prospectus obtained by the **Wall Street Journal** on **20 October** gives **Anthropic** first-half 2026 revenue of **US$16.3bn**, against **US$1.1bn** a year earlier, and a net loss of **US$80.7bn** — roughly double the **US$42bn** lost across the whole of 2025.[1]

The loss is mostly an accounting shadow of success. About **US$72bn** of it is non-cash, arising from revaluing convertible instruments as the company's own valuation climbed: the bonds investors hold convert to equity, so the firm books its appreciation as an expense. Compute and infrastructure took about **US$9bn** in the half, more than the **US$7.3bn** spent in all of 2025.[1]

The commitments are the durable number. The draft names non-cancellable cloud obligations of **US$111bn to Google, US$110bn to Amazon Web Services and US$31bn to Microsoft**, with total contracted compute near **US$450bn**. Its own risk section says those three suppliers **"increasingly treat it as a competitor rather than a customer"**, and that about **20 per cent** of revenue comes from two customers.[1]

One caution belongs in the lede, not a footnote: this is a draft, reported second-hand. A search of the **SEC's EDGAR** system for an Anthropic registration returns **no matching companies**.[1]

US$72bn

THE NON-CASH SHARE OF THE HALF-YEAR LOSS — AN EXPENSE BOOKED BECAUSE THE COMPANY'S VALUATION ROSE[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Nvidia pays its suppliers up front. At GTC Berlin on **21 October** the company named six packaging and test partners and disclosed a **US$1.1bn capacity reservation advance** to Taiwan's **King Yuan Electronics** for US test plants, high-volume from **April 2027**, plus a multibillion-dollar advance to **IBIDEN**'s Ono plant for triple capacity from early 2028. Substrate capacity rises **2.5×** over three years. Testing capacity should **double from 2026 to 2027**, with a **Singapore** buildout reaching volume in **February 2027**.[3]

Beijing restricts AI exports and exempts open weights. MOFCOM's **Announcement No. 48** of **16 October** proposes controls on **40 technologies, 23 of them artificial intelligence**, 14 prohibited and 26 restricted, with comment to **15 November**. There is **no published performance threshold** of any kind. Technology already public through **open-source release or academic publication is not subject to control**.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE MEMORY MARKET IS EATING THE INCREASE

TrendForce now expects **PC DRAM supply to fall in 2027**, after forecasting **15–20 per cent** price rises late this year. **Micron** has grown overall supply **25 per cent** and prices still rose, because high-bandwidth memory burns more wafer per usable gigabyte; little new capacity is expected before about **2029**.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A BEAR CASE NINETY-THREE PER CENT BELOW THE TALK

Kyle Guske II, senior investment analyst at **New Constructs**, models Anthropic on a mature social-media profile and reaches **US$144bn** — about **93 per cent below** the two-trillion-dollar valuation discussed for the listing. His firm called it the **"most ridiculous IPO of 2026"** and an **"unprecedented test"** of investor gullibility. His note predates the draft by twelve days and does not address its figures.[2]

The commitments are contractual and the loss is notional. Which of the two the market decides to price is the question November answers.

SOURCES 1 Dealroom (21 October 2026), Seoul Economic Daily's English edition (22 October) and Notebookcheck (21 October), all read at source, reporting a draft prospectus reviewed by the *Wall Street Journal* on 20 October — for revenue, the loss and its non-cash component, compute spend, the Google, AWS and Microsoft commitments, the $450bn total, the risk language and the November listing target. **These are press reports of an unaudited draft, not a filing. A direct search of the SEC's own EDGAR database for an Anthropic S-1 or F-1 returns "No matching companies". One third-quarter revenue figure is rendered inconsistently across the three reports and is omitted.** 2 24/7 Wall St., 8 October 2026, read at source, for Kyle Guske II of New Constructs, the US$144bn valuation, the 93 per cent gap and both quoted phrases. **It predates the draft and responds to the reported valuation, not these accounts.** 3 **Nvidia's own newsroom release of 21 October 2026, read at source**, for the six partners, the King Yuan and IBIDEN advances, the 2.5× substrate figure, the doubling of test capacity and the Singapore buildout. **Effectively single-sourced to the company.** 4 **MOFCOM and the science ministry's Announcement No. 48 and its spokesperson Q&A, read at source**, for the 40 technologies, the 23 AI entries and the consultation deadline; Xinhua, 16 October, for the open-source carve-out. **Attachment 1 carries the technical scope and is reproduced on neither page; no AI threshold is printed because none is published.** 5 Notebookcheck, 21 October 2026, read at source, relaying TrendForce. **TrendForce's own report was not read at source.**

THE HOME LAB · RECURSIVE'S FLINT

Recursive releases Flint, a forty-billion-parameter model that fits a 48GB box

The NVFP4 build measures 22.9 gigabytes and scores within 0.7 points of the 16-bit original. Ollama's support shipped the same day as a release candidate.

Recursive published **Flint** at **19:28 UTC on 21 October** under **Apache 2.0**: **39.8 billion** parameters with about **2.5 billion** active per token, across **49 layers**, with **256 routed experts**, six chosen per token, plus a shared expert.[1]

The footprints are the news. The **Q4_1** GGUF weighs **26.0GB** and the card asks for an Apple Silicon Mac with **48GB** of unified memory, its worked example running the full **262,144-token** context. The **NVFP4** build is **22.9GB**. The unquantised checkpoint is about **80GB**.[1]

Recursive also published what most releases omit: what the quantisation costs. The output head is cut to four bits with an offline distillation stage using the 16-bit model as teacher, and the finished **NVFP4 build lands within 0.7 points of the original** across the benchmark set — **54.9 per cent on Terminal-Bench 2.1, 89.7 on SWE-bench Pro v2, 74.2 on SWE-bench Verified**.[1]

The speed claims are the maker's own and short-context: **above 125 tokens a second** on an M4 Pro MacBook Pro, **above 150** on a 64GB RTX Spark. No independent benchmark existed anywhere this desk could read on 22 October, and the blog and the model card disagree about the context window — 512,000 against **262,144**. The card is the narrower, and the one printed here.[1]

22.9GB

THE NVFP4 BUILD OF A 39.8-BILLION-PARAMETER MODEL, WITHIN 0.7 POINTS OF THE 16-BIT ORIGINAL[1]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

The runtime arrived before the runtime arrived. Ollama 0.40.8-rc0, tagged **16:20 on 21 October**, adds Flint and says plainly: **"Flint is supported on MacOS. Other GPU support will be enabled in a subsequent release."** The stable channel was still on **0.40.7**, so the first thing many met was a version wall.[2]

Ten llama.cpp builds in one day. Tags **b11790 to b11800** all landed on **21 October**; b11791 alone fixes memory leaks in the **Metal** capture path.[2]

Matter Server 1.5.0, and a valve you can calibrate without IKEA. Released **20 October**, 1.5.1 and 1.5.2 following next day: groundwork for Matter 1.6.1 Groupcast, two-way camera audio behind a **talkback** parameter, clusters for the **Aqara FP400**, and an **IKEA ValveCalibration** panel that calibrates radiator valves **with no IKEA hub**.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE SECRETS ROW, AND WHO WROTE THE FIX

A Home Assistant issue opened **16 October — "i never authorized an integration that scans my secrets"** — drew **251 points and 234 comments** on Hacker News. A maintainer replied that it was **"not an invasion of privacy"** and closed it **"won't fix"**; the thread was locked as too heated; he then apologised, explaining that the Supervisor sends only the **first five characters of a SHA-1 hash** to Have I Been Pwned, matched locally. The documentation fixing it was **generated with an AI coding agent**. The default is still on.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A QUANTISATION STEP ACTUALLY COSTS

No independent test of Flint exists yet, so the honest caution is the published literature. **Uygar Kurt**'s evaluation of llama.cpp quantisation on Llama-3.1-8B (arXiv, January 2026) puts **Q4_K_M** at **69.15** average against the 16-bit **69.47** — free, in effect. One step further to **Q3_K_S** buys **8 percentage points** of file size and costs **9.3 points of GSM8K**, 77.63 down to **68.31**, with perplexity up from 7.32 to 8.96. Vendors quote the step that flatters them.[5]

A coding model of this class fitting one 48GB machine is the week's real change. That its maker published the quantisation delta is the part worth copying.

SOURCES 1 **Recursive's own release post of 21 October 2026 and the Hugging Face model cards for Flint and its int4 and NVFP4 builds, read at source** — for the parameter counts, layer and expert architecture, Apache licence, the 26.0GB and 22.9GB footprints, the 48GB requirements, the 262,144-token context, the distillation of the output head, the 0.7-point delta and the three benchmark scores, and for the tokens-per-second claims. **The speed figures are the maker's own, at short context; no independent benchmark could be found on 22 October, and the only corroboration located was a post by a company-affiliated author. The blog and the card disagree on context length and the card's figure is used.** 2 **The Ollama and llama.cpp release pages on GitHub, read at source**, for the 0.40.7 and 0.40.8-rc0 notes and the quoted macOS-only line, and for tags b11790–b11800; the version-wall complaint is a Hacker News item of the same day. 3 **The matter-js server changelog, read at source**, for 1.5.0 of 20 October and the 1.5.1 and 1.5.2 patches; Matter Alpha for the Groupcast groundwork, the talkback parameter, the Aqara clusters and the IKEA valve panel. **Home Assistant core shipped nothing between 16 and 22 October.** 4 **The Home Assistant documentation issue and the pull request that resolved it, read at source on GitHub**, for the quoted replies, the apology, the five-character hash prefix and the pull request's own statement that it was generated with an AI agent. 5 Uygar Kurt, arXiv:2601.14277, read at source, for the quantisation benchmark figures. **Q2_K was not evaluated there and no Q2 figure is attributed to it.**

THE KIT · APPLE'S IPHONE DUO

Apple ships the iPhone Duo on Friday at S$3,099 in Singapore

Reviews landed on 21 October. Joanna Stern's machine folded the hinge more than 32,000 times; the under-display camera is where reviewers stop being kind.

Apple's first folding phone goes on sale in **Singapore on Friday 23 October**, priced on the company's own store at **S$3,099** for 256GB, **S$3,399** for 512GB, **S$3,999** for a terabyte and **S$4,899** for two, in Star White and Night Sky, **limit two per customer**. The American price is **US$1,999**.[1]

The hardware, from Apple's own specification: a **7.6-inch** inner folding display and a **5.4-inch** outer, both **3,000 nits** peak with ProMotion to **120Hz**; an **A20 Pro** on a vapour-cooled chassis; **48-megapixel** main and ultra-wide cameras, a front camera and a second one **under the display**; and **31 hours** of video on the inner screen, 44 on the outer.[1]

The first independent measurements are less flattering than the spec sheet. **9to5Mac** weighed it at **254 grams**, about five more than an iPhone 18 Pro Max, and measured **11.3mm closed** — roughly **29 per cent thicker** than the Pro Max — folding to **5.2mm** open, with a shut footprint of **117.8 by 84.1mm**.[2]

The number everyone wanted was the hinge, and it held. **Joanna Stern** of the *Wall Street Journal* folded and unfolded the phone **more than 32,000 times** by machine. It showed no fault afterwards, though a measuring device found the hinge **slightly stiffer** at the end than at the start. Stern also judged the matte nano-texture inner panel easier to read in sunlight than a Galaxy Z Fold8's, and the crease less visible than Samsung's — **but still visible**, which Apple's marketing implies it is not.[3]

32,000+

MACHINE FOLDS OF THE IPHONE DUO HINGE BEFORE REVIEW, WITH NO FAILURE — AND A MEASURABLY STIFFER ACTION AFTERWARDS[3]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Leica charges US$9,950 for carbon and a colour profile. The **Q3 43 Formula 1 Edition**, announced **21 October**, is **772g — 21g lighter** than the standard Q3 43 — with a carbon-fibre grip carrying an **integrated Qi coil**, a microvelour covering and an exclusive "Leica Look" filter. The sensor and the 43mm f/2 APO-Summicron are unchanged. That is a **US$2,000** premium. **No Singapore price is published**; the local store refused this desk.[4]

Insta360's drone halves its price and gains 102 grams. Antigravity's **A1 "Follow Me"** bundle, on sale **20 October** at **US$799** against US$1,599, swaps the goggles for a **1.7-inch wrist display** and a Drag-to-Fly ring. The catch is regulatory: its high-capacity battery lifts take-off weight to **351g**, past the **249g** registration threshold the standard bundle stays under — and the buyers it targets are the ones least likely to want to register a drone.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE CAMERA NOBODY IS DEFENDING

Across the launch reviews the complaint converges on one part: the **under-display front camera** takes poor pictures, especially backlit or in low light, and reviewers advise folding the phone shut to use the punch-hole camera instead. There is **no telephoto lens**; the phone runs hot under sustained load; the top volume buttons are awkward on a call; and unoptimised third-party apps still appear in a small window with black bars, or sideways.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE REVIEWER WHO LIKED IT SAYS DON'T BUY IT

Chance Miller of 9to5Mac is broadly positive and still writes: the Duo **"is heavy, and I start to feel it in my wrist when using it one-handed for extended periods"**; moving Touch ID to the side button **"feels like a step backward"**; it **"isn't the best camera Apple sells today"**. His verdict is the one to quote: **"For most people, a traditional iPhone is still the practical purchase right now."**[2]

A first-generation folding phone from the company that waited longest is still a first-generation folding phone. The hinge is solved; the camera behind the screen is not.

SOURCES 1 **Apple's own Singapore store and iPhone Duo product pages, read at source**, for the 23 October availability, all four Singapore prices, the two finishes, the two-per-customer limit and every published specification quoted here; the US$1,999 American price as reported by 9to5Mac. 2 9to5Mac's review by Chance Miller, published 21 October 2026, read at source, for the 254-gram weight, the 11.3mm and 5.2mm thicknesses, the 29 per cent comparison, the folded footprint and every quoted line. 3 Notebookcheck's round-up of the launch reviews, 21 October 2026, read at source, for Joanna Stern's 32,000-fold machine test and the stiffer-hinge measurement, the nano-texture and crease observations, and the convergent criticisms of the under-display camera, heat, buttons and app scaling. **The Verge's review was refused to this desk and is not quoted.** 4 Leica Camera USA's own store page and Notebookcheck, both 21 October 2026, read at source, for US$9,950, the 772-gram weight and 21-gram saving, the carbon grip with its Qi coil, the microvelour and the unchanged optics. **Leica's Singapore store returned HTTP 429 and no SGD price is printed.** 5 DPReview, 20 October 2026, read at source, for the US$799 and US$1,599 bundles, the watch and ring, the 8K specification, the 351-gram take-off weight against the 249-gram threshold and the publication's own point about the audience. **No Singapore price is published for the A1.**

THE GOOD LIFE · ESOTERIC'S GRANDIOSO K1XE

Esoteric prices the Grandioso K1XE at US$45,000, its converter now discrete

The Tokyo maker has dropped the bought-in chipset for its own FPGA design. Its published distortion figure is 0.001 per cent.

Esoteric announced the **Grandioso K1XE** from Tama, Tokyo, on **21 October**, shipping internationally from the beginning of November. The trade press puts it at **US$45,000**, with the matching **PS1XE** external power supply at **US$19,000 — US$64,000** as a stack. Esoteric's own release carries no price in any currency, and no yen figure is published anywhere this desk could read.[1][2]

What has changed is the converter. Where almost every rival buys a chipset from ESS or AKM, Esoteric has built a **new-generation FPGA-based multi-level delta-sigma** design in house, fully dual-mono. The transport is the VRDS-ATLAS, **6.6kg for the mechanism alone**; the output stage claims **2,000 volts per microsecond**; five independent linear supplies feed it. The player weighs **34.3kg**, the power supply **23.3kg**.[1]

The published performance is where the argument starts. Esoteric states a signal-to-noise ratio of **113dB** and distortion of **0.001 per cent** at 1kHz. Those are respectable numbers. They are not, in 2026, exceptional ones — converters costing a fiftieth of this routinely measure better on both.[1][2]

No independent measurement exists and no owner community has formed: the machine is a day old, and the threads under its name concern the outgoing K1X. This desk found nothing quotable and is not inventing a verdict.[2]

0.001%

ESOTERIC'S PUBLISHED DISTORTION AT 1KHZ, WITH 113DB SIGNAL-TO-NOISE — GOOD FIGURES, NOT RECORD ONES, AT US$45,000[1]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Technics returns to the booth. The **SL-1210MKX**, unveiled at Amsterdam Dance Event on **21 October**, lists at **€1,499 / £1,299** and ships **January 2027**. New: a dedicated **±4 per cent** pitch range, a first for the SL-1200 line, and a **±50 per cent** range; a heavier chassis and new isolation feet. It weighs **11.9kg** against the MK7's 9.6. **Wow and flutter is not published**, and neither is the added chassis mass — for a machine sold on vibration resistance, that is the missing number.[3]

A time-only watch at CHF 129,000. Renaud Tixier's **Monday Skeleton**, shown **20 October**, runs its micro-rotor calibre at a leisurely **2.5Hz**, in **15 pieces per colour**, with **262 components and 238 inward angles**. A conflict this desk could not resolve: one outlet calls the case 18k **white** gold, another **gray**; both were read at source.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE SKELETON ARGUMENT, IN FOUR LINES

Under Fratello's piece on the Renaud Tixier, readers divide on whether skeletonisation is craft or display. **erranto** finds the genre **"derivative… to the point they don't have identity"**; **Hans** calls such watches **"(precision) mechanical toys"**. Only **dave** is unreserved: **"This is how Monday should always have looked."**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · ASK FOR THE DEMONSTRATION, NOT THE FAITH

Ian White, reviewing the K1XE's announcement for ecoustics, puts the case plainly: **"the published specifications alone don't establish an audible advantage over the previous K1X SE"**, and **"at this price, the audible benefit needs to be demonstrated rather than taken on faith"**. He notes the stack **"raises the obvious question of diminishing returns, particularly when the complete system approaches the price of a rather nice automobile".**[2]

Esoteric has done the hard, unfashionable thing — designed its own converter rather than buying one. Whether that is audible at sixty-four thousand dollars is a question its own specification sheet does not answer.

SOURCES 1 **Esoteric's own press release of 21 October 2026, read at source**, for the Tama dateline, the November shipping window, the discrete FPGA converter, the VRDS-ATLAS masses, the 2,000V/µs slew rate, the five linear supplies, the component weights and the 113dB and 0.001 per cent figures. **The release carries no price in any currency and no yen price is published anywhere this desk could reach.** 2 ecoustics (Ian White) and Best of High End, read at source, for the US$45,000 and US$19,000 prices and every quoted line of White's assessment. **No independent measurement of this machine exists, and no owner-community sentiment is quoted because none could be found — the threads under the name concern the outgoing K1X.** 3 **The Technics press release of 21 October 2026, read at source**, for the €1,499 and £1,299 prices, the January 2027 availability, the new pitch ranges and the heavier chassis; ecoustics and StereoNET for the 11.9kg and 9.6kg weights. **The company publishes no US price, no wow-and-flutter figure and no comparative isolation data; the launch-day forum thread refused this desk, so no community line is quoted.** 4 Watches by SJX and Fratello, both 20 October 2026, read at source, for the CHF 129,000 price, the fifteen pieces per colour, the 2.5Hz frequency, the component and angle counts, and the four reader comments quoted under their posted handles. **The white-gold against gray-gold discrepancy is between those two sources and is printed rather than resolved; the brand's own site does not list the watch.**

SCREEN & SOUND · STREET FIGHTER

Paramount's Street Fighter opens first with $30.8m from 3,575 theatres

The opening beat the inflation-adjusted lifetime domestic gross of both earlier Street Fighter films combined. Break-even is put near $205m worldwide.

Paramount's **Street Fighter** took **$30,775,377** on the weekend of **16–18 October** from **3,575** theatres, an **$8,608** per-screen average and the weekend's number one. Directed by **Kitao Sakurai**, it carries an **$82m** production budget and had reached **$55.6m** worldwide by **20 October**, of which **$20.1m** came from outside the United States.[1][2]

Set that against the franchise it revives. The **1994** film opened to **$6.8m** — **$15.3m** in today's money — and finished at **$99.4m** worldwide; **2009**'s *The Legend of Chun-Li* opened to **$4.7m** and made **$12.8m**. Together the two earlier films took **$22.8m** domestically in adjusted terms. This opening weekend alone beat that.[3]

The reviews did not follow the money. **Rotten Tomatoes** has it at **41 per cent** from 125 critics against a **78 per cent** audience score from more than 2,500 verified ratings; **Metacritic** gives **44** from 26 reviews with a **6.8** user score. **Helen O'Hara** in *Empire*, at 60: **"It's silly and overstuffed, but there's a sense that Sakurai and his cast are in on the joke and having fun with it." Shaurya Thapa** of *Time Out*: **"It's** *The Expendables* **on nitrous."**[4]

The same weekend **Focus Features** opened **Sense and Sensibility**, directed by **Georgia Oakley**, to **$7,203,465** from 2,545 theatres — and to the month's sharpest critical split.[15]

$22.8m

INFLATION-ADJUSTED DOMESTIC LIFETIME OF BOTH PREVIOUS STREET FIGHTER FILMS COMBINED — LESS THAN THIS FILM'S OPENING WEEKEND[3]

ALSO THIS WEEK

A seventy-point spread on one film. *Sense and Sensibility* holds **77 per cent** at Rotten Tomatoes and a Metascore of **71** from 41 critics — inside which **Peyton Robinson** of RogerEbert.com scores it **100** (**"executed with tactile sincerity and incredible emotional acuity"**) and **Kyle Smith** of the *Wall Street Journal* scores it **30**: **"All of the sparkle of that film has turned to ash in this superfluous and inert bore."** The audience is warmer than the press at **89 per cent**.[5]

Tatsuro Yamashita tops Oricon at seventy-three. The live album **JOY 2**, released **14 October** on Warner Music Japan for his **fiftieth** solo year, entered Oricon's combined album chart at number one with **107,392 points** for the week to 18 October. At **73 years and 9 months** he is the second-oldest artist to top it, after Eikichi Yazawa, and his first since *SOFTLY* in July 2022 — a gap of **four years and four months**.[6]

THE CHATTER · THE READERS AUDIT THE RECORD CLAIM

Under Screen Rant's box-office piece the comments did the arithmetic the headline skipped. A reader posting as **IAN** on the "most money for a video game franchise" framing: **"Ummm Mario did 140 mil in its opening weekend"**; another, **Cameron**, on **"link bait headlines like this one"**. The record being set is a *Street Fighter* record, not a video-game-film record, and the distinction is the whole story.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · MADE FOR THE CAP TABLE

Trace Sauveur of AwardsWatch, scoring it **16 out of 100**, calls it **"a movie made for shareholders, not movie fans"**. **Rodrigo Perez** of The Playlist, at 33, lands the more interesting complaint: **"So, it's a gloriously stupid movie, too afraid to be genuinely gloriously stupid."** On an $82m budget, break-even is put at roughly **$205m** worldwide — against $55.6m after five days.[3][4]

Two openings, one weekend, and the same lesson twice: the aggregate score is the least informative number published about either film.

SOURCES 1 **Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 16–18 October 2026, read at source**, for both films' grosses, theatre counts and per-screen averages. 2 **The Numbers, read at source**, for the $82m budget, the $55,631,241 worldwide and $20.1m international totals through 20 October, the release date, director and cast. 3 Screen Rant, 17 October 2026, read at source, for the 1994 and 2009 comparisons raw and adjusted, the combined $22.8m figure, the ~$205m break-even estimate, and both reader comments under their posted handles. **Its CinemaScore of B- is reported second-hand there and is not printed as read at CinemaScore.** 4 **Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, read at source**, for the 41 and 78 per cent, the Metascore of 44, and the O'Hara, Thapa, Sauveur and Perez quotations with their scores. 5 **Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, read at source**, for *Sense and Sensibility*'s 77, 89 and 71, and the Robinson and Smith reviews. 6 **Oricon's own weekly ranking page for the chart dated 26 October 2026, read at source**, for the 107,392 points and the release date; Oricon's news article via syndication (the original served as mojibake) for the double crown, the age record behind Eikichi Yazawa and the gap since *SOFTLY*. **107,392 is a POINTS total on a combined ranking, not a copy count. A "thirteenth number one" claim and a "six decades" record appear only on a retailer page that refused this desk, and neither is printed. No English-language review of the album exists and none is invented. Billboard, Variety and Deadline all refused this desk.**

THE FAMILY DESK · SCREENS & DEVELOPMENT

JAMA Pediatrics pools 2.8 million children and finds no executive-function effect

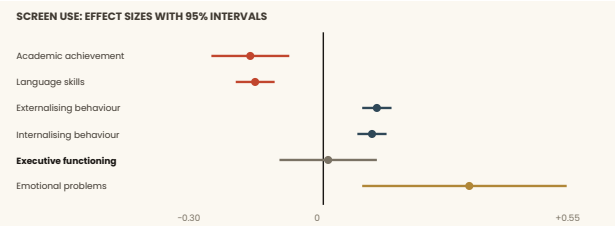
Sheri Madigan's team reviewed 23 meta-analyses across 64 countries. Academic achievement and language moved; attention and maths did not.

A **JAMA Pediatrics** umbrella review published on **28 September** pooled **23 meta-analyses** covering **2,817,252** children in **64 countries**, with **Sheri Madigan** of the University of Calgary as corresponding author. It converts every effect to a correlation, making the findings easy to read against one another.[1]

Two domains moved. **Academic achievement** came in at **−0.15** (95% CI −0.23 to −0.07) and **language skills** at **−0.14** (−0.18 to −0.10) — small, but with intervals clear of zero. Internalising sat at **0.10**, externalising at **0.11**.[1]

Several did not move at all. **Executive functioning** — attention, working memory, self-control, the thing parents most fear losing — came out at **0.01**, interval **−0.09 to 0.11**: indistinguishable from nothing across nearly three million children. **Mathematics**, **science** and **reading** crossed zero too.[1]

And the biggest-looking number is the softest: **emotional problems** at **0.30** carries an interval of **0.08 to 0.50**, a lower bound weaker than the academic finding. The review also notes that **age moderated** several associations — so a pooled estimate across everyone under 18 is not an estimate for a twelve-year-old.[1]



A *Meridian* chart. Source: *JAMA Pediatrics* umbrella review, 28 September 2026. A bar crossing the zero line is a finding consistent with no effect. Executive functioning straddles it; the widest bar, emotional problems, is also the least precise.

WHAT TO DO WITH IT THIS WEEK

The evidence points at the reading hour, not the whole day. The damage this review can see is in **achievement and language**, not attention or arithmetic — which argues for protecting the blocks where reading and talking happen, homework and the half-hour before sleep, rather than a blanket cut.[1]

Singapore parents are not confident, and say so. The communications ministry's own **2025** survey found **only 37 per cent** felt confident managing their children's digital activities.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE INSTRUMENT CAN AND CANNOT SEE

Esther van Sluijs, professor of behavioural epidemiology at Loughborough, on the review's reach: it **"cannot draw robust conclusions about specific types of screen use, like social media use or gaming"**, and **"cannot say much about whether higher screen use leads to poorer outcomes"**. **Víctor González Calatayud** of Murcia adds that the academic finding **"must be interpreted with considerable caution"**, and that correlation and causation need keeping apart.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LEAST RELIABLE NUMBERS ARE THE ONES QUOTED

Tatiana Íñiguez Berrozpe, vice-dean for ICT in education at Zaragoza, says the effect sizes **"in no way support the mantra that screens are the main cause of adolescent emotional distress"** — and, of the two large emotional findings that will travel furthest, that they **"are the least reliable estimates in the article"**. This is general guidance, not medical advice.[2]

An umbrella review measures measurements. This one says the harm is real, small, concentrated in schoolwork and language — and absent where the argument has put it.

SOURCES 1 **Al-Jbouri E, Nivison MD, Neville RD and colleagues,** *JAMA Pediatrics*, **online 28 September 2026 (doi:10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4339), abstract read at source** — for the 23 pooled meta-analyses, the 2,817,252 participants across 64 countries, every effect size and interval quoted, and the note that age moderated some associations. **The pooled sample is everyone aged 18 or under; it is not an estimate specific to a twelve-year-old, and is not presented as one.** 2 **The Science Media Centre's expert reaction of 28 September 2026, read at source**, for the van Sluijs, González Calatayud and Íñiguez Berrozpe quotations, each given verbatim with the speaker's own title. 3 **The Ministry of Digital Development and Information's own release of 31 May 2026, read at source**, for the 37 per cent parental-confidence figure and the more-than-half wanting further support. **All three Singapore parenting forums this desk tried refused it, so no parent-forum comment is quoted anywhere on this page. Family and health content in MERIDIAN is general guidance and not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · SINGAPORE'S EXPERT PANEL

Singapore's MOH panel puts girls' risk window at 11 to 13

Josephine Teo says self-declaration "is just not good enough". Legislation on age checks is expected early in 2027.

The health ministry's expert panel on social media and mental health, co-chaired by **Lim Choon Guan** of the Institute of Mental Health and **Lee Jungup** of the National University of Singapore, reported on **30 July**. Its paragraph 25 is the one a parent should read: the negative effects on life satisfaction are strongest in early adolescence, and **"these critical periods occur around ages 11 to 13 for girls and ages 14 to 15 for boys"**.[1]

That sentence rests on a 2022 *Nature Communications* paper by **Amy Orben** and colleagues, which followed **17,409** young people aged 10 to 21 within a sample of **84,011** and found higher estimated use predicting a fall in life satisfaction a year later.[2]

The local prevalence sits underneath it: **36 per cent** of Singaporeans aged 15 to 17 spend more than three hours a day on social media, **18 per cent** of those aged 10 to 24 show signs of problematic use, and **39 per cent** of heavy users aged 15 to 17 report severe symptoms of depression.[1]

The policy is arriving behind it. **Josephine Teo** has said self-declaration of age **"is just not good enough"**; six services are designated — Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, X, YouTube and, remarkably, the local hardware forum **HardwareZone** — autoplay would be off by default for teenagers, a daily cap is under consideration, and the legislation is expected **early in 2027**. Under-13s would be blocked; 13-to-17s keep access with safeguards.[3]

11–13

THE YEARS SINGAPORE'S OWN PANEL IDENTIFIES AS GIRLS' SHARPEST SENSITIVITY WINDOW — AND THE YEARS A SECONDARY ONE PUPIL IS LIVING THROUGH[12]

WHAT TO DO WITH IT THIS WEEK

Spend the capital on eighteen months, not on a rule meant to last to eighteen. The window is sex-specific and short, and the panel's own mechanism is **sleep and social comparison**. That points at two levers rather than a ban: a hard device curfew, and turning off visible like and follower counts, which is now a setting on both Instagram and TikTok.[1]

Fix the birthday on the account now. If she holds an account on any of the six designated services, expect an age re-verification prompt inside the legislative window — and expect it to fail if the stated date of birth is wrong. It is a two-minute settings change today and an appeal later.[3]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE BACKS THE RULES AND PLANS TO DODGE THEM

One survey of Singaporeans this year found **84 per cent** believe age-restricted content harms minors, **81 per cent** would verify their own age to keep minors out, and **84 per cent** support government regulation — while **46 per cent** said they would switch to a **less secure service** rather than submit to the checks. The support and the evasion are the same people.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE GOVERNMENT'S OWN PANEL ARGUES AGAINST A BAN

The panel declines the simple policy in its own report: **"definitive causal links… have not yet been established"**, though the association is consistent; and it is **"concerned that blanket age-based restrictions do not distinguish between harmful and beneficial uses of social media, and risk being counterproductive should young people easily circumvent age restrictions"**. **Roy Ka-Wei Lee** of SUTD adds the other cost: strict verification creates real data-privacy risk.[15]

MOH guidance already discourages social media below twelve. A reader with a daughter born in July 2014 has just watched her cross that line into the window the same ministry says matters most. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 **The Ministry of Health's Expert Panel report on the mental-health impact of social-media use, 30 July 2026, PDF read in full** — for the co-chairs, the paragraph 25 age windows quoted verbatim, the 36, 18 and 39 per cent prevalence figures, the causal caveat, the passage opposing blanket age restrictions, and the existing guidance discouraging use below twelve. 2 **Orben A, Przybylski AK, Blakemore S-J and Kievit RA,** *Nature Communications* **13:1649, 28 March 2022, abstract read at source via Europe PMC** (nature.com redirected to an authentication wall), for the 84,011 and 17,409 samples and the age range. The outcome measured is **self-reported life satisfaction**, not a clinical diagnosis. 3 Mothership and AsiaOne, 31 August 2026, read at source, reporting Josephine Teo's interview of 28 August, for the quoted line, the six designated services, default-off autoplay, the daily limit under consideration, the age split and the early-2027 timing. **The ministry's own factsheet gives no date for the social-media extension.** 4 The Jumio 2026 Online Identity Study via Biometric Update, read at source, for all four percentages. **A commissioned industry survey, flagged as such.** 5 A Singapore schools and parenting site, 31 August 2026, for Roy Ka-Wei Lee's data-privacy caution. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · RATES & THE DOLLAR

The Fed is tightening and the 2s10s curve flattened to 32bp

September CPI ran at 3.7 per cent. Housing starts fell 5.2 per cent inside an error band of 11.8, and the dollar moved on it anyway.

Start with the fact most commentary gets backwards. The **federal funds target is 3.75 to 4.00 per cent**, set on **17 September** by a **25 basis-point increase** — the only move of 2026. This is a tightening cycle: the question on **28 October** is whether they go again, not whether they cut.[1]

Inflation is why. September's **CPI**, published **14 October**, rose **0.6 per cent** on the month — above seven per cent annualised — and **3.7** over the year against 3.6 expected, core **2.6** against 2.5.[2]

Then the brake. September's residential construction, out on **20 October**, put starts at **1,221,000** annualised, **"5.2 percent (±11.8 percent) below"** August. Read the parenthesis: the error band is more than twice the decline, and the Census Bureau says it may take six months to establish a trend. The dollar slipped on it regardless, toward **101.7**.[3][4]

So the curve flattened the awkward way. The **10-year** sits at **5.13 per cent** and the **2-year** at **4.81** — a spread of **32 basis points**, in from **38** on 19 October. The long end did the moving; the front end is pinned by a bank that may still hike. **Brent at $109.73** stands **$12.02** above **WTI**, a seaborne-risk premium out of Hormuz (p3).[4][5]

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

VWRA[6]	$192.28	▲ 0.48%
Global agg (AGGU)[6]	$5.77	▲ 0.19%
US 2-year[4]	4.81%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year[4]	5.13%	▲ 1bp
DXY[5]	101.71	0.00%
USD/SGD[5]	1.2773	▲ 0.01%
Brent[5]	$109.73	▲ 0.86%
Gold[5]	$4,140.83	▲ 0.39%
Bitcoin[5]	$84,638	▲ 2.10%

Levels at the 21 October close. The Straits Times Index closed **5,437.99**, up 0.63 per cent. Not investment advice.[4][5]

-0.71%

TOTAL RETURN ON THE GLOBAL AGGREGATE BOND ETF OVER A YEAR, AGAINST **+15.55%** FOR THE ALL-WORLD EQUITY FUND[6]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR EQUITIES, BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

Over twelve months the global-equity line returned **15.55 per cent** including dividends; the global-aggregate bond line returned **−0.71**. A sixty-forty of exactly those two made about **9.0 per cent** — some **six and a half points** less than equities alone, and it bought no protection: on **14 October** the hot print sent equities down and yields up together. The counter is that at a **5.13 per cent** ten-year, the bond sleeve's forward compensation is the best in two decades.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · GOLD IS NOT NEAR A RECORD

Gold is **8.1 per cent below its own second-quarter average**: the World Gold Council puts the **LBMA PM average at US$4,506.29** in the second quarter, against Wednesday's **$4,140.83**. The day was risk-on — the Nasdaq 100 up **1.13 per cent**, bitcoin **2.1** — and gold rose with them. That is not haven behaviour.[5][7]

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER DOLLAR FLAT RISK-ON A hawkish floor under a risk-on tape, over an economy splitting in two: housing contracting while anything touching AI capital spending runs hot (p5).

SOURCES 1 **The Federal Reserve's own open-market page, read at source**, for the 3.75–4.00 per cent target, the 25 basis-point increase of 17 September 2026 as the year's only listed move, and the 28 October meeting. **A market-implied hike probability circulated this week; the exchange's own tool returned HTTP 503 and no probability is printed.** 2 **The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own September CPI release of 14 October, read at source**, for the monthly, annual and core figures; consensus comparisons from a market wrap read at source. 3 **The Census Bureau's own release CB26-162 of 20 October, PDF read as text**, for the 1,221,000 starts, the quoted "5.2 percent (±11.8 percent)" language, completions, and the Bureau's own six-month caution. 4 **The US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file, read at source**, for the 2- and 10-year yields from which the 32 and 38 basis-point spreads derive. 5 TradingEconomics for the dollar index, crosses, Brent, WTI and the Straits Times Index, with **gold corroborated at Kitco, Brent at oilprice.com and bitcoin at two exchanges**, read at source. **These are reference quotes, not settlements; the dollar index is the least corroborated line.** 6 **stockanalysis.com's own VWRA and AGGU pages, read at source**, for prices and the stated one-year total returns of 15.55 and -0.71 per cent; **the sixty-forty figure is this desk's arithmetic on those two numbers. No published equity-bond correlation dated October 2026 could be found, and none is quoted.** 7 **The World Gold Council's** *Gold Demand Trends* **for Q2 2026, read at source**, for the US$4,506.29 LBMA PM average; **the Q3 edition was unpublished when this page closed. Market explanation, not investment advice.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · RETROCOMPUTING RESTORATION

Retrocomputing's busiest room is a Discord about a $750 video scaler

AmiBay carries 1,055,216 posts and 25,994 members. The RetroTINK server has 21,533 people in it, and sells no computers at all.

Three hobbies share one name, and the people in them separate them sharply. **Collecting** acquires and displays machines, where condition matters and function is optional. **Emulation** runs the old software on new silicon. **Restoration** takes a dead machine and makes it work at component level — desoldering a failed chip, replacing every electrolytic capacitor, patching a corroded trace with a wire. It is the only one of the three where you can lose.[1]

The baseline ritual has a mechanism. Electrolytic capacitors are small cans of chemical paste that dry out, swell and leak over thirty or forty years; the leak is conductive and corrosive, and eats the copper wiring printed on the board. One Amiga restorer, **Georgios Sokianos**, counted **nineteen** on a single A1200: the fluids **"spread... underneath them and breaking the motherboard traces"**. You replace all of them, then find what else is broken.[2]

What draws people in is rarely the machine. The most-shared on-ramp here is **Paul Ford**'s essay "The Sixth Stage of Grief Is Retro-Computing", which drew **799 points** on Hacker News in **November 2014** — and the comments are the real document. One reads: **"booting up MS-DOS 3.3 and System 7.5 after my wife and child have gone to sleep."** Another, eight years later, supplies this desk's title unprompted: **"This is a deep rabbit hole, I have unfortunately fallen into."**[3]

Underneath the grief is something practical. A Commodore 64 has about twenty chips and a published schematic; you can hold the whole thing in your head, which is not true of anything built after 1995. The pleasure is the diagnosis.

1,055,216

POSTS ON AMIBAY, THE EUROPEAN AMIGA MARKETPLACE — ACROSS 131,371 THREADS AND 25,994 MEMBERS[4]

THE SIZE OF THE WORLD

The forums trade; the Discords argue. The Retro Web, the hobby's hardware database, holds **23,764** motherboard entries. But the live rooms are elsewhere: **RetroTINK's Discord has 21,533 members**, **MiSTer FPGA's 20,565**, and the Vintage Computer Federation's own just **1,516**. **VCF Southwest** drew over **1,800** people in person this year; **AmiWest** runs this weekend in Sacramento.[4][6]

And the teachers are on YouTube. LGR has **1.82 million** subscribers, but the restorers people learn method from are smaller: **Adrian's Digital Basement** at **250,000** across 631 videos, and **Noel's Retro Lab** at **78,200** from only **120** — a ratio that tells you how long a real repair film takes to make.[5]

THE CHATTER · A DAY ON THE BENCH, WRITTEN UP

The genre's daily newspaper is an aggregator called **The Oasis BBS**, which carried eleven dated posts in three days this week — among them **"Amiga 500 Black Screen Traced to a Failed Serial Driver"**. In a repair-a-thon it wrote up, a diagnostic cartridge accused the **PLA**, the chip everyone blames; the PLA tested fine in a known-good machine, and the real fault was a **good BASIC ROM sitting on top of a bad one**, unconnected.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS COUNTED THESE PEOPLE

Every number above is a platform counter, not a census. This desk found **no credible demographic survey** of retrocomputing restorers anywhere, so no age, income or country breakdown appears on these three pages. Four of the largest forums — the Federation's own, AtariAge, English Amiga Board and Lemon64 — publish counts this desk could not read, and none is printed either.[4]

Over the next two pages: what they fight about, what the bench costs, and the ninety-day path in — including the two purchases that most often end badly.

SOURCES 1 The three-way distinction is this desk's synthesis of how the communities below describe themselves. 2 Georgios "walkero" Sokianos, "Recapping Amiga computers", 19 April 2019, read at source, for the nineteen capacitors on one A1200 and the quoted description of electrolyte damage. 3 The Hacker News thread on Paul Ford's "The Sixth Stage of Grief Is Retro-Computing", 6 November 2014, read at source, for the points, the comment count and both quoted reader comments under their posted handles; **the essay itself refused this desk, and the thread is quoted rather than the article**. The second quotation is a separate Hacker News comment of 17 November 2022. 4 **AmiBay's own statistics block and The Retro Web's own counters, read at source on 22 October 2026**; Discord member counts read the same day from each server's own public invite data. **VCF Forums, AtariAge, English Amiga Board and Lemon64 all refused this desk and no figure is printed for any of them. No demographic survey of the hobby could be found and none is estimated.** 5 YouTube channel headers read at source on 22 October 2026. 6 The VCF Southwest and AmiWest event pages, read at source. 7 The Oasis BBS, posts of 19–21 October 2026, read at source.

THE DEEP END · THE BENCH

A Hakko desoldering gun costs €356 and the Commodore costs $116

The money has moved off the machines and onto the bench and the video chain. A loose C64 indexes at $115.99; the scaler to display it runs to $750.

The hobby's central argument is whether to diagnose or to replace. The reflex answer to any dead machine is **"recap it"**, and a restorer writing as **LinuxJedi** spent a long post last November arguing that it **"is not a panacea for all problems"**. His own Amiga 1200 was fixed not by capacitors but by a **bodge wire** across a broken data line — and he had received a board sold as recapped on which **"almost every SMD capacitor was soldered backwards"**.[1]

The other school has the scars. Amiga surface-mount capacitors leak a conductive, corrosive electrolyte that destroys the traces beneath them, and lifting one can tear the copper with it. The settled middle: recap those unconditionally, diagnose everything else.[2]

Two older arguments are over. The **Gotek**, a USB stick pretending to be a floppy drive, was once cheating; on Applefritter the verdict now reads **"Goteks are pretty much accepted as a necessary step in the future of Vintage computing"**. And original chips against modern replacements has been won by the replacements, because the originals are finite.[3]

What is not settled is the picture. The scaler camp is enormous; the best opposing case comes from **Carl Svensson**, who turns emulator filters off: **"I've never seen a filter that can properly convey the peculiarities of a real world CRT."** Both sides agree on that. They disagree about keeping a tube in the house to get it.[4]

62,289

VIEWS ON ONE EEVBLOG FORUM THREAD ABOUT A SINGLE DESOLDERING TOOL — THE HAKKO FR-301[5]

THE BENCH, PRICED AT SOURCE

The iron. Skip the forty-euro station: it cannot hold temperature against a ground plane, which is what a 1982 motherboard is. The entry point is the **Hakko FX-888DX** at **€157.99**; the step up is cartridge-tip, **PACE ADS200** from **€379**. One correction for anyone following old advice: the **JBC CD-2BE** the forums still name is marked **DISCONTINUED** on JBC's own page.[5][6]

The gun, which is the real unlock. Lifting a 40-pin chip out of a 1984 board without destroying the pads wants a vacuum desoldering gun, not a hand pump. The **Hakko FR-301** is **€355.99**, nozzles **€22.99–33.99** each, and it was out of stock at the retailer this desk read. Add a **Hakko Omnivise** board holder at **€89.90** — two hands, one board, one iron is the difference between a repair and a lifted pad.[5]

Seeing the fault. A twelve-bit **Rigol DHO802** is **€380.80**; a **Korad KD3005D** current-limiting bench supply is **€74**, hot air **€159.99**. The supply matters more than the scope: it is what stops a short becoming a second fault.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHERE THEY ACTUALLY ARE

AmiBay is not a chat forum but a market — Want to Sell, Want to Buy, Group Buys, Services. **Applefritter** holds the Apple II and vintage Mac thread, and the **EEVblog** forum is where retro people argue about tools rather than machines. **RetroRGB**, the video-signal desk of record, published **Weekly Roundup #536** on 21 October — over ten years of unbroken weekly posts.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · YOU WILL SPEND FOUR TIMES THE MACHINE

Lay the verified prices side by side. A loose **Commodore 64** indexes at **$115.99**. The scaler to display it properly runs **$475 to $750**. The gun to fix it is **€355.99**. The scope to find the fault is **€462.91**. The cheapest line item in the entire hobby is the capacitors, at about **£5** a board; the most expensive single object most people buy is a video scaler. The computer is somewhere in the middle, and it is not the point.[8]

Which is the honest shape of it. This is not a hobby about owning old computers, but about owning the instruments that make old computers answer.

SOURCES 1 LinuxJedi, "Why Recapping Isn't Always the Cure", 11 November 2025, read at source, for the quoted argument, the bodge-wire repair and the backwards-soldered capacitors. 2 Georgios "walkero" Sokianos, 19 April 2019, for the electrolyte damage and the torn trace. **The "settled middle" is this desk's characterisation, not a quotation.** 3 Applefritter, October 2023 and February 2024, read at source, for the Gotek verdict under its posted handle. **The claim that replacements have won is this desk's reading of the products named on p17, not a community vote.** 4 Carl Svensson, "The Effect of CRTs on Pixel Art", datagubbe.se, read at source. 5 **Reichelt's and welectron's own product pages, read at source on 21–22 October 2026**, for every euro price quoted, each including German value-added tax. **The FR-301 was listed as temporarily unavailable when read.** The view figure is the EEVblog thread's own counter. 6 **JBC's own product page**, which carries the DISCONTINUED stamp on the CD-2BE. 7 AmiBay's own section list and RetroRGB's roundup of 21 October 2026. 8 PriceCharting's Commodore index and RetroTINK's own shop. **PriceCharting states its figures come from completed sales on eBay and other marketplaces; eBay refused this desk, so the index is attributed to PriceCharting.**

THE DEEP END · THE WAY IN

Applesauce+ opens pre-orders at $295 as Commodore ships hardware again

Christian Simpson bought the brand in 2025 and now runs it from a YouTube channel. The C64 Ultimate starts at $299.99.

Three things genuinely changed in the last twelve months. **Applesauce+**, the floppy-preservation controller, opened pre-orders on **21 July** at **$295**, raising flux resolution to **96MHz** from 16 or 24 — a real technology step. **RetroTINK** shipped firmware **1.99.1** on **17 October**. And **SuperSwitch HD** arrived on **20 October** at **$150**, using a programmable chip to recreate the video output while the original console does the rest.[1]

The fourth change is stranger. **Commodore** is a going concern again: the brand was bought in **2025** by the YouTuber **Christian Simpson**, and the company is shipping a **C64 Ultimate from $299.99**. The honest counterweight sits in the same window — **Mirari Proto 2**, 100 new-build motherboards announced in August, **delayed three times** by October. That is the real face of the cutting edge: component shortages, not launch hype.[2]

For anyone starting, the first month costs nothing: read the daily aggregator, join the two big servers. Then buy, in order, a **Hakko FX-888DX**, two tips, a **Korad** bench supply, a **Rigol DHO802**, an **Omnivise**, a **£19.99** diagnostic cartridge, a **£5.95** capacitor pack cut for your exact board revision, and a loose untested **Commodore 64** — about **€890**, roughly **S$1,290**. The desoldering gun, the scaler and the Fluke are month-four decisions.[3]

THE VOCABULARY

Recapping — replacing every electrolytic capacitor as a matter of course. **Shotgunning** — the pejorative: swapping parts instead of diagnosing. **Trace rot** — corrosion of the printed copper under a leaking capacitor. **Bodge wire** — an insulated wire soldered across a broken connection.

The RIFA bang — the yellow mains-filter capacitor that fails with, in one owner's words, **"a bang, brown goo and a nasty stink that hangs around for a week"**. **Dead test** — a cartridge that boots a machine too broken to boot itself and names the dead chip. **PLA** — the one logic chip in a C64 that everybody blames and that is often innocent.

Flyback — the high-voltage transformer in a CRT, and the discharge ritual before touching anything. **Dot crawl** — the shimmer along colour edges in composite video, and the reason people buy scalers.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT WILL NOT SHIP TO SINGAPORE

The structural problem for a reader here is logistics, and it is verifiable. **Retroleum**, which cuts the capacitor packs per board revision, **ships to the United Kingdom only**. **Individual Computers** stopped shipping to the United States in **December 2025** and suspends dispatch for weeks at a time — including **16 to 26 October 2026**, as this issue went out. Check the shipping page before the shopping list.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A TUBE HOLDS TEN TONS AND A CHARGE

The hardest physical limit is the display. The standard repair reference is blunt: **"The voltages in even the smallest CRT monitor can be lethal"**; a large tube **"will have over 10 tons of air pressure attempting to crush it"**; an unpowered set is not safe, because the capacitance **"can hold a charge for quite a while"**. On posting one: **"each stage of shipping is roughly the equivalent of your monitor being dropped down a flight of stairs."** And from inside the community: **"I think emulation is the sincerest form of preservation for these old systems."** The software survives either way; what a restorer keeps is the object.[6][7]

NEXT DESCENTS

Bookbinding & book repair — bone folders, linen thread, and an archival-materials rabbit hole.

Freshwater aquascaping — carbon dioxide, substrate chemistry and a Japanese design tradition.

Orienteering — map, compass, forest and a clock; a thinking endurance sport.

SOURCES 1 **The Applesauce project's own site and shop, read at source**, for the 21 July 2026 pre-order date, the $295 price and the 96MHz flux resolution; **RetroRGB, 17 October 2026**, for firmware 1.99.1; the SuperSwitch HD announcement of 20 October for the $150 board and its hybrid architecture. 2 Commodore's own site and the Retro Recipes channel description, read at source, for the 2025 acquisition, Christian Simpson's role and the C64 Ultimate from $299.99; the Mirari Proto 2 pages for the 100-board run and the three recorded delays. 3 **Reichelt, welectron, tfw8b.com and retroleum.co.uk, read at source**, for each item and price in the starter list, and PriceCharting for the loose C64; **the €890 and S$1,290 totals are this desk's arithmetic, at an approximate rate**. 4 Definitions compiled by this desk from the sources on p15–p16; the RIFA quotation is a forum owner's, read at source. **"Dot crawl" is standard composite-video terminology and is attributed to nobody.** 5 **The shipping and announcement pages of Retroleum and Individual Computers, read at source on 22 October 2026.** 6 Samuel M. Goldwasser's Sci.Electronics.Repair CRT FAQ, read at source, for all four quoted passages. 7 A Hacker News comment of 17 November 2022, read at source, quoted under its posted handle. **Reddit was not reachable for this desk, as for the previous seven issues, and nothing on these three pages is sourced to it.**

FITNESS · PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

Ferrari and Libardi find progressive overload pays only after session eighteen

Thirty-one adults trained one leg progressively and one at a fixed load for twelve weeks. Int J Sports Med puts the gap between sessions 18 and 24.

A trial published online on **15 October** in the *International Journal of Sports Medicine* used the cleanest design available: each of **31** untrained young adults had their **two legs randomised** against each other, one to rising load, one to a fixed one. Both did three sets of ten to twelve repetitions of knee extension, twice a week for **twelve weeks**, with cross-sectional area measured after sessions **6, 12, 18 and 24**.[1]

The progressed leg won, narrowly and late. Cross-sectional area rose **3.36cm²** against **2.67**, with a protocol-by-time interaction at **p = 0.002** — but **no significant difference at any individual time point**. The whole effect sits in one window, **sessions 18 to 24**, where the difference in change was **1.22cm²** (95% CI **0.59 to 1.84**).[1]

The explanation is in the effort data. Repetitions left in reserve — how far from failure each set stopped — held almost flat in the progressed leg, from **0.47** at the first session to **0.20** at the twenty-fourth. In the fixed-load leg it drifted from **1.50** to **4.08**. The unprogressed leg did not stop training. It stopped trying, by exactly the amount the lifter got stronger.[1]

A separate trial points the same way with a bigger gap. **Kassiano** and colleagues, in *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise* in February, took **55** untrained young women through eight weeks of unilateral elbow extension: triceps thickness rose **0.79cm (22.9 per cent)** with progression against **0.41cm (11.6)** without, and **0.05cm** in controls.[2]

1.50 → 4.08

REPS LEFT IN RESERVE IN THE FIXED-LOAD LEG, FIRST SESSION TO TWENTY-FOURTH — FOUR SHORT OF FAILURE[1]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

The bedtime shake does not wreck the recovery score. A randomised, double-blind crossover of **25** NCAA Division I female athletes, published **20 October**, gave **40g** of casein, alpha-lactalbumin, carbohydrate or placebo on three consecutive nights each. **No significant effect on anything**: total sleep time spanned **7.47 to 7.62 hours** across all four arms, efficiency **91.5 to 92.0 per cent**.[3]

Though the instrument has its own problem. That study's objective data came from one wrist strap — and the best independent validation of six consumer wearables against laboratory polysomnography, **62 adults, mean age 46**, found specificity of only **29 to 52 per cent**. The straps see sleep; they do not reliably see its stages.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE RESEARCH REVIEWERS ARE ALREADY HEDGING

Writing in **Layne Norton**'s research review, **Brandon Roberts** headlines the finding as "progressive overload builds more muscle, but beginners can still grow without it", and adds the caution the gym does not: **"the evidence is not as straightforward as the gym mantra makes it sound"**, and that it **"complicates the idea that you need to work hard every set or every workout to grow"**.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO LEGS, ONE JOINT, NOBODY TRAINED

Both trials ran in **untrained** participants on a **single-joint, single-limb** model, and neither resembles a mid-forties lifter's full-body week. The new one found **no difference at any individual time point** — the whole result is one interval between sessions 18 and 24 — and its abstract reports no age range, no sex split and no effect sizes. The Kassiano authors say whether unprogressed training stays effective over longer periods **remains unresolved**.[12]

The practical reading is not "add weight": it is that a fixed load becomes an easy one, and the number to watch is not on the bar but in the last two repetitions. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 **Ferrari O, Silva DG, Camargo JBB and colleagues (Libardi CA, senior author), "Time course of muscle hypertrophy with and without progressive overload",** *International Journal of Sports Medicine*, **online 15 October 2026, doi 10.1055/a-2980-6473 — abstract read at source via Europe PMC** (the publisher served a bot interstitial), for the within-subject design, the 31 participants, the prescription and schedule, both cross-sectional-area changes, the p = 0.002 interaction, the absence of any significant difference at individual time points, the 1.22cm² difference with its interval, and every repetitions-in-reserve figure. **The abstract reports no age range, no sex split and no effect sizes.** 2 **Kassiano W and colleagues,** *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise* **58(7):1556–1565, online 19 February 2026, abstract read at source**, for the 55 participants, the eight-week protocol, all three thickness changes and the authors' unresolved-question conclusion. **No confidence intervals are reported.** 3 **Paterson KGP and colleagues (Ormsbee MJ, senior author),** *Journal of the International Society of Sports Nutrition* **23(1), online 20 October 2026, abstract read at source**, for the crossover design, the 25 recruited and 21 completing, the four 40-gram conditions and every range quoted. **All objective outcomes came from a single consumer wrist device.** 4 **Schyvens AM and colleagues,** *Sleep Advances* **6(2), 22 March 2025, abstract read at source**, for the 62 participants, the mean age of 46 and the specificity range. **It publishes no device-specific figure for the strap used above, and none is inferred.** 5 Brandon Roberts in REPS issue 49, June 2026, read at source. **It discusses the Kassiano trial, not the new one. General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE DIARY · BOOKING THIS WEEK

Tokyo's Louvre show opens final-week ticketing at noon on 31 October

The Orsay centenary at Ueno admits every under-18 free from 14 November. Shojo Manga Infinity's advance price closes on 27 October.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

24 & 25 Nov ★ **Diana Krall Live in Singapore**
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL, 8PM · **CAT 1 S$268 TO CAT 6 S$88 · THE PAGE ALSO ADVERTISES "FROM $74.80", WHICH ITS OWN TABLE DOES NOT SUPPORT**

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · 40 EVENTS, **SEVERAL FREE**

26–29 Nov ★ **The Nutcracker, State Ballet of Georgia**
SANDS THEATRE · **S$68–208**, RATED **GENERAL** · PRICES SECONDARY

18 Nov–6 Dec **Eureka Day, Singapore Repertory Theatre**
KC ARTS CENTRE · S$48–78, **YOUTH S$28 · ADVISORY: MATURE CONTENT**

3–6 Dec **Voices · A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE · WORKSHOPS FROM **S$15**

to 21 Nov **Junior and the Holiday Magic**
DRAMA CENTRE · PITCHED YOUNGER THAN TWELVE · NO PRICE PUBLISHED

16 Feb–14 Mar ★ **Moulin Rouge! The Musical**
SANDS THEATRE · **RATING STILL UNCLASSIFIED** — DO NOT ASSUME A FAMILY BOOKING · DATES SECONDARY

Jan–Feb 2027 **KidsFest! 2027**
DRAMA CENTRE · FIVE UK SHOWS · **S$42–72**, SECONDARY

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

14 Nov–28 Mar ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO · **¥2,400, ADVANCE ¥2,200 · FREE FOR EVERY VISITOR 18 OR UNDER**

to 13 Dec ★ **Renaissance Masterpieces from the Louvre**
NATIONAL ART CENTER · **FINAL-WEEK TICKETS FOR 7–13 DEC GO ON SALE ONLINE ONLY AT NOON, SAT 31 OCTOBER**, ¥2,400

13 Nov–11 Jan ★ **Magical Winter, Warner Bros. Studio Tour Tokyo**
TOSHIMAEN, NERIMA · ADULT **¥6,300–7,300**, **JUNIOR 12–17 ¥5,200–6,000** · THE FORBIDDEN FOREST UNDER SNOW

28 Oct–8 Feb **Shojo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
NATIONAL ART CENTER · **ADVANCE ¥2,000 CLOSES 27 OCTOBER**, THEN ¥2,200

31 Oct–28 Mar **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM · WEEKDAY **¥2,800** · **JUNIOR HIGH AND UNDER FREE**

30 Oct–11 Jan **Haruichi Furudate · HAIKYU!! Challengers**
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY · **PRICE UNVERIFIED** — THE GALLERY'S PAGE ERRORED

23 Oct–11 Jan **Takehisa Yumeji · An Artist Who Defined His Era**
NATIONAL MUSEUM OF MODERN ART · WITH *AMIS DE PARIS*, BOTH CLOSING 11 JAN · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED

11–31 Jan ★ **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · **PRICE BANDS UNVERIFIED**; THE TICKETING HOST REFUSED

PLANNING NOTES · AND WHAT THIS DESK DROPPED

Three deadlines fall before November. Shojo Manga Infinity's advance price closes **27 October**; the Louvre show's final-week timed tickets open at **noon on 31 October**, and nothing else admits you after 6 December; **Ghibli Park** releases January dates at **2pm on 10 November**, Japan time. **Three Tokyo shows are free for a twelve-year-old. Dropped for want of a bookable date:** Chingay 2027, which has announced nothing; Wild Rice's *Goldilocks*, in the window but not on sale; and the **Tokyo Marathon**, whose ballot was drawn on 11 September. **Still barred:** Post Malone, and the Dee Dee Bridgewater duo of 29 October, cancelled.

SOURCES 1 **Esplanade's own event pages, read at source**, for the Diana Krall dates and full price table — including the "from $74.80" line its own category prices do not support — and for Kalaa Utsavam and Voices. 2 **The Singapore Repertory Theatre's own page** for Eureka Day's dates, prices, youth rate and mature-content advisory. 3 **The live ticketing records for Moulin Rouge!, The Nutcracker and KidsFest! 2027, read at source**, each checked for a cancellation marker and carrying none; **Moulin Rouge! is listed with its rating still unclassified. Dates and price bands for these three could not be obtained from a primary venue or producer page and are secondary-sourced, as flagged in each row.** 4 **The Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum's, the National Art Center's, the Mori Art Museum's and MOMAT's own English pages, read at source**, for every Japanese date, price and free-admission rule, and the Louvre show's 31 October on-sale. 5 **Warner Bros. Studio Tour Tokyo's own pages** for the dates, all three age bands and the described content. 6 **Ghibli Park's own English site** for the 10 November release; **the Tokyo Marathon's own site** for the closed ballot; **the Australian Open's own site** for its dates. 7 Chingay's own site shows no 2027 dates; Wild Rice's page says *Goldilocks* goes on sale in 2027. **Every Singapore row was checked against the live ticketing record for a cancellation marker on the day this page closed.**

THE TABLE · FOUR SINGAPORE OPENINGS

NAE:UM opens the 34-seat Osteria Da Su on Telok Ayer Street

Tokyo Onigiri's queue has doubled to an hour since it opened on 12 October, and its first real review is mixed.

The **NAE:UM Group**, which holds a Michelin star for its modern Korean room of the same name, opens its first non-Korean restaurant on **Friday 23 October**. **Osteria Da Su** sits at **163 Telok Ayer Street**, next door to the star, with **34 seats** and chef **Suji Park** — Korea-born, two decades cooking Italian. Spaghetti alle vongole at **S$28++** substitutes Korean water parsley; tortelli at **S$30++** are filled with braised short rib. **Too new to call**: everything published is a preview from a media tasting, and the room has not served a paying table.[1]

Tokyo Onigiri is this desk's return visit, and it has earned one. The brand began in Tokyo as Ichiryu Manpuku in **2023** under **Yuka Hayakawa**, reached Mongolia, then Taiwan, and opened its sixth outlet at **One Raffles Place** on **12 October**: rice balls moulded to order, nori from Omori, **S$4.90** to **S$10.90**. The verdict is in and it is mixed. HungryGoWhere found the sambal chicken sweet and said it **"tasted a bit like"** a convenience-store onigiri. The harder number is operational: **waits have gone from about 30 minutes on day one to roughly 60.**[2]

Two more worth the trip. **Soft Order**, at **213 Henderson Road** inside a light-industrial block, opened officially on **12 October**: an all-day room built to a Seoul template with its own bakery, sourdough from **S$6**, udon at **S$16.90**, sous-vide steak at **S$28** in the evening. Honeycombers calls it **"a promising player in our cafe scene"**; the useful warning is that the shio pan sold out by 2pm on a Friday, because there is one bake, at eleven. And **Blue Label Tavern**, the gastropub spin-off of the Blue Label pizza rooms, is the first tenant open at the rebuilt **Stamford Place**, with a **S$18** smash burger and a rotisserie bird at **S$19** a half.[3][4]

60 min

TOKYO ONIGIRI'S REPORTED LUNCHTIME WAIT, UP FROM ABOUT 30 ON ITS OPENING DAY[2]

THE BUZZ · WHAT THE REVIEWERS ACTUALLY SAID

The Ranting Panda scores Blue Label Tavern **4 out of 5** overall — value **3.5** — liking the chicken dunks as **"an addictive snack"** and calling the burger **"pretty decent"**. The dissent is specific: **"the options are less than Blue Label Pizza"**, the pizzas here are **10-inch against 12** at the other outlets, and the J-Dog is only **"quite safe to go for"**. On Soft Order, Honeycombers' **Yuki Ling** rated the Brussels sprouts **"a flavour explosion"** and the udon **"a must-try"**, while a second write-up issued no verdict at all.[3][4]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE OF THESE FOUR CANNOT BE JUDGED YET

Only Blue Label Tavern has a full scored review. Osteria Da Su has not opened; Soft Order has one enthusiastic write-up and one that declines to conclude; Tokyo Onigiri has exactly one real verdict, and it is lukewarm. Two of the four publish nothing but an Instagram account. **None of the four is halal-certified**, and three take no bookings of any kind — so the only lever a diner holds is the hour they turn up.[1][2][3][4]

THE HONESTY LEDGER

Soft Order — no chef or owner is named by any source, so none is named here. **Tokyo Onigiri** — last covered at its opening in No. 133; this is its second and final run.[2][3][4]

TELOK AYER · HENDERSON ROAD · ONE RAFFLES PLACE · CIVIC DISTRICT

Four rooms, three of them without a reservation system between them. In a city this booked, walking in at eleven is becoming a strategy.

SOURCES 1 Eatbook, 12 October 2026, and Little Big Red Dot, read at source, for Osteria Da Su's 23 October opening, the address, the 34 seats, the NAE:UM Group relationship, chef Suji Park and every dish and price quoted. **Both are previews written from a media tasting, not reviews; no verdict exists and none is invented. A third outlet published 28 October against two closer sources giving the 23rd.** 2 Eatbook, 13 October, and HungryGoWhere, read at source, for Tokyo Onigiri's Tokyo origin, founder, expansion, address and opening date, the price tiers, the quoted criticism and the thirty-to-sixty-minute wait. **Eatbook carries no verdict; the verdict quoted is HungryGoWhere's alone.** 3 The Honeycombers (7 October) and Great New Places (12 October), read at source, for Soft Order's address, hours, prices, the quoted assessments and the sold-out shio pan. **The second piece issues no verdict. No chef or owner is named by either, so none is named above.** 4 The Ranting Panda, 7 October 2026, read at source, for Blue Label Tavern's scores, the quoted praise and dissent and the prices; the developer's own Stamford Place announcement for the tenancy. **SETHLUI, Daniel Food Diary and Time Out Singapore all refused this desk; Instagram returned rate limits, so no social chatter is quoted. Halal status was checked for all four and none is certified.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN

Japan's National Police Agency reaches 2.9 per cent of fraud ringleaders

Thirty-three years of law reduced Japan's yakuza to 17,600 members. What replaced them, which the agency calls tokuryū, has no members at all.

In **Machida**, western Tokyo, in August, a woman in her eighties took a call from a man who said he was from the post office, about a suspicious parcel addressed to Hong Kong. A second man called, said he was a police officer in Shizuoka, and asked where she kept her money. He told her to put her **one million yen** in the refrigerator — even a burglar, he explained, will not look there. He rang daily to ask whether she had moved it, and when she next planned to go out. Five days after the first call, while she was out, someone let themselves in and took it.[1]

Nobody in that story had a name, and that is not a failure of the reporting. It is the design.

Japan now loses money to fraud on an industrial scale. The National Police Agency's own organised-crime report for 2025 records **27,758** cases of what it calls special fraud, up **31.9 per cent**, with losses of about **¥141.42 billion** — a rise of **96.7 per cent** in a single year. A second category, investment and romance fraud run through social media, accounts for a further **15,142** cases and about **¥182.70 billion**. Together that is roughly **¥324 billion**, about two billion US dollars, taken in twelve months.[2]

The police needed a word for whoever was taking it, and nothing in their vocabulary fitted. What they settled on is **嗅名・流動型犯罪グループ** — *tokumei ryūdō-gata hanzai gurūpu*, "anonymous, fluid-type crime groups" — which the agency itself contracts to **トクリュウ**, *tokuryū*. It does not name an organisation. It names a shape: no membership, no premises, no territory, no hierarchy that can be decapitated. The agency's definition says the core has been anonymised, that participants are loosely linked through social media and job-recruitment sites, that roles are subdivided — and, of the people who do the actual work, uses a single word: **使い捨て**, *tsukaisute*, disposable.[2]

It does not name an organisation. It names a shape — and the police invented it because nothing they already had would hold.

使い捨て — tsukaisute. The agency's own word for the people who do the work: disposable.

Disposable is accurate. Of everyone arrested in 2025 for the main money-raising offences the agency attributes to tokuryū, only **about one in ten** held the position of principal or instruction-giver. Early twenties are the largest cohort at **23.4 per cent**; those under thirty are about **60 per cent** of the total. Roughly **three in ten** entered the crime by answering a recruitment post on social media — the advertisements known in Japanese as **闇バイト**, *yami baito*, dark part-time work.[2]

In 2025 the agency counted, for the first time, how many of them were children. The answer was **1,322** people under twenty: 425 for fraud, 247 for theft, 200 for drug offences, 116 for robbery. Juveniles reached the work through acquaintances more often than through advertisements. Separately, **27** juveniles were arrested or cautioned over illegal online gambling, nine times the previous year and a record; eight were in junior high school; the youngest was **twelve**.[3]

¥324bn

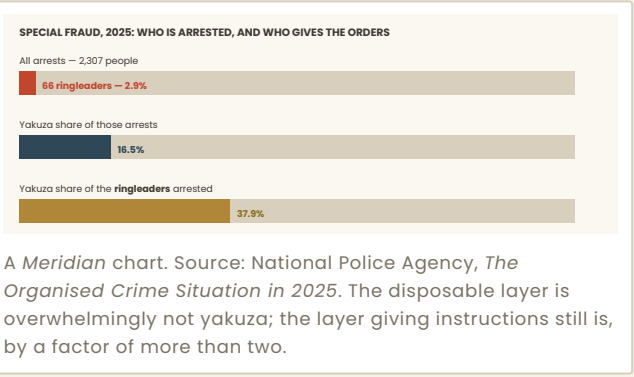
TAKEN BY THE TWO MAIN FRAUD CATEGORIES IN 2025 — ABOUT TWO BILLION US DOLLARS, AND A NINETY-SEVEN PER CENT RISE IN SPECIAL FRAUD ALONE[2]

SOURCES 1 The Machida case as reported by NewsOnJapan, read at source. **Single-sourced; the victim is not named there or here.** 2 **The National Police Agency's own report "The Organised Crime Situation in 2025", the confirmed-value edition published April 2026, downloaded as PDF and read as extracted text** — the figures are not in the HTML version. For the 27,758 special-fraud cases, the 31.9 per cent rise and the ¥141.42bn in losses at 96.7 per cent growth; the 15,142 social-media investment and romance cases and their ¥182.70bn; the agency's own definition of 嗅名・流動型犯罪グループ and its contraction, including the word 使い捨て; the roughly one-in-ten principals; the 23.4 per cent early-twenties share and the sixty per cent under thirty; and the three-in-ten recruited through social-media advertisements. **The two fraud categories are counted separately by the agency and are summed here by this desk, which says so rather than presenting ¥324bn as a published total.** 3 Jiji Press, 26 February 2026, read at source, for the 1,322 juveniles and the offence breakdown, for the finding that juveniles arrive through acquaintances more than advertisements, and for the 27 juvenile online-gambling cases, the eight junior-high pupils and the twelve-year-old. **2025 is the first year the agency counted juvenile tokuryū arrests at all, so there is no prior-year comparison and none is implied.**

To understand what tokuryū is, start with what Japan did to the thing it replaced. The **Anti-Boryokudan Act** took effect in **1992**, and it worked. At the end of **2025** the National Police Agency counted **17,600** yakuza members and associates — **9,400** full members and **8,200** associates — the lowest since that law came into force. The series runs **20,400**, then 18,800, then 17,600. Arrests of yakuza fell to **7,335**, down **11.1 per cent** and also a record low, from 11,735 five years before.[1]

Thirty-three years of patient suppression, and a measurable win. It is the part of the story Japan can be proud of, and the part that explains the rest.

Because what grew in the space is not an organisation at all. It is a labour market. A person who wants a robbery committed does not need members, premises or a name; they need an advertisement, a messaging app, a bank account and somebody's afternoon. Each of those can be bought separately, per job, from strangers who never meet. The thing the 1992 law was built to dismantle — a hierarchy with a letterhead — is precisely the thing the new structure declines to have.



A *Meridian* chart. Source: National Police Agency, *The Organised Crime Situation in 2025*. The disposable layer is overwhelmingly not yakuza; the layer giving instructions still is, by a factor of more than two.

Which is where the argument has to be careful, because the agency's own table contains the strongest objection to it. Of everyone arrested for special fraud in 2025, yakuza members and associates were **16.5 per cent**. Of the *ringleaders* arrested, they were **37.9 per cent** — and that share has run between **38 and 53 per cent** for five straight years. The agency writes, in its own words, that yakuza keep multiple groups beneath them and parcel the offences out.[1]

So "anonymous and fluid" may describe only the bottom of the structure. Read uncharitably, tokuryū is not a new species at all: it is the old one, shedding its skin, having discovered that deniability is cheaper than membership. A boss who once needed a hundred sworn men now needs a job advertisement and a burner account, and when the police arrive they find a nineteen-year-old who has never met him.

The number the whole essay turns on sits one line further down the same page. In 2025, **2,307** people were arrested for special fraud. Exactly **66** of them were ringleaders. That is **2.9 per cent** — and it was itself a **32 per cent improvement** on the year before.[1]

Two further objections belong here. The category is a police artefact and a young one: juvenile tokuryū arrests were counted for the first time only in **2025**, and the agency concedes that establishing these groups' core is **not easy**. It is also the state's **second** attempt at naming the same shape — the 2025 report introduces tokuryū as arriving *in addition to* the 準暴力団, the "quasi-boryokudan", named for the same purpose in **2013**. Two labels in twelve years is itself a finding.[1]

And ordinary law still works when it is pointed at something specific. Japan passed a metal-theft act in **June 2025**; thefts of cable from solar installations fell from **7,054 to 3,856**, down **45.3 per cent**, and mass shoplifting fell **41.6**. A sceptic may say the problem was never that the shape is unpolicable, only that fraud is lucrative and the statutes lagged.[1]

> ***Two thousand three hundred and seven arrests. Sixty-six principals. A police force can be extremely busy and still not be reaching anybody.***

And it is getting worse while the arrests rise. Fraud losses in the first half of **2026** reached a provisional **¥181.62 billion**, up **¥61.88 billion** or **51.7 per cent** year on year — the worst January-to-June on record, announced on **30 July**. That is roughly **a billion yen a day**, every day, through a country with one of the lowest violent-crime rates on earth.[2]

SOURCES 1 **The National Police Agency's own report "The Organised Crime Situation in 2025", April 2026, PDF read as extracted text** — for the 17,600 members and associates at end-2025 with its 9,400 and 8,200 split and the agency's own statement that this is the lowest since the Anti-Boryokudan Act took effect in 1992; the 20,400 / 18,800 / 17,600 membership series; the 7,335 yakuza arrests, the 11.1 per cent fall and the five-year series from 11,735; the 16.5 per cent and 37.9 per cent shares and the five-year ringleader series; the agency's description of yakuza keeping groups beneath them; and the 2,307 arrests, 66 ringleaders, 2.9 per cent share and its 32 per cent year-on-year rise. 2 A Japanese regional daily, 31 July 2026, read at source, reporting the agency's announcement of 30 July: first-half 2026 losses of a provisional ¥181.62bn, up ¥61.88bn and 51.7 per cent year on year, the worst January–June on record. **The daily-rate figure is this desk's arithmetic on that provisional total, and is given as approximate. A higher figure for losses to end-August circulated this week in a politician's post citing an agency briefing; it could not be confirmed against the agency's own release and is not printed. The reading of tokuryū as the yakuza shedding its skin is this desk's argument, built on the agency's figures; it is not the agency's own characterisation.**

A state that arrests twelve thousand people a year and reaches three per cent of those giving the orders has two options. It can accept the loss, or it can stop regulating the market and start participating in it. Japan has chosen the second, three times in eighteen months.

First, the police began forging identity documents. **仿装身分捕査** — disguised-identity investigation — means officers answering *yami baito* advertisements on fake papers. In **2025** the agency ran **13** such operations, producing two arrests for preparing a robbery and three for attempted fraud, and preventing harm in **seven** cases. The method was studied in **2010 to 2012** and shelved, on the ground that manufacturing a driving licence is forgery of an official document. It proceeds now on **Article 35 of the Penal Code**.[1][2]

Second, from **June 2027**, the police will forge bank accounts. Under a law revised in **June 2026** they may open accounts under **fictitious names**, with the banks' cooperation, and sell them to people trying to buy accounts — posing as vendors, then freezing the account when stolen money lands. Penalties for account trading rise to **three years** and **¥5 million**. The market has published prices: about **4,300** trading cases in 2024, an account selling for around **¥35,000**, up roughly **half** in a decade, one recorded at **¥500,000** — and more than half of all fraud money moves by transfer.[3]

The state has begun manufacturing the two things the market runs on: false papers, and accounts that are not what they say they are.

Third, and six days before this issue went to press, the Cabinet approved a bill on **16 October** allowing police to **remotely access and analyse the phones** of tokuryū suspects — before an offence, in order to prevent it. It amends the **Police Duties Execution Act**, and it goes to an extraordinary session of the Diet. An expert panel chaired by **Toshihiro Kawaide** of the University of Tokyo had recommended it on **24 September**; the method, reportedly, will be intrusion software, which the police have not described.[4]

The objections are mostly about silences. One Japanese writer who went through the draft declined to say whether he supported it, and listed what the bill does not say: no technical method of entry is specified, only **"necessary measures for connection, copying and acquisition"**; no obligation falls on application makers; and a panel member is reported conceding that police may have to exploit vulnerabilities in the device. His question is the right one — who holds the intrusion tools, and how well? He points at Japan's own **Digital Agency breach**, detected **25 June 2026** and announced on **11 September**.[5]

When this same statute was opened in **2025** for active cyber defence, the **Japan Federation of Bar Associations** demanded three conditions on any power to reach into a machine: temporal imminence, no other reasonable means, and no serious harm to another state's essential interests. The 2026 bill carries one limitation, that there be no other way of collecting the information.[6] A crime reporter quoted in a Japanese legal outlet doubts the whole enterprise anyway: the people who place the advertisements use Signal and Telegram, which leave nothing behind.[2]

This is not a crackdown. A crackdown is the same force applied harder. It is a conversion — from the power to punish, which needs a defendant, to the power to pre-empt, which needs only a suspicion and a device.

There is a date on which we will know. If the ringleader share of special-fraud arrests moves off **2.9 per cent** in the agency's report due in **April 2027**, the new powers are reaching the people who matter. If it does not, Japan will have rewritten three statutes, taught its police to counterfeit, and still be arresting the disposable. Every rich country with a gig economy is behind it in the queue.

SOURCES 1 **The National Police Agency's own "Organised Crime Situation in 2025", April 2026, PDF read as extracted text**, for the 13 disguised-identity operations of 2025 and their outcomes. 2 A Japanese legal news outlet, 20 December 2024, read at source, for the 2010–12 review that shelved the technique on forgery grounds, Article 35 of the Penal Code as the current basis, and the crime reporter's scepticism about Signal and Telegram. **That reporter is unnamed in the original and is not named here.** 3 Jiji Press via AdnKronos, 28 September 2026, read at source, for the June 2026 revision permitting fictitious-name accounts, the June 2027 start, the penalties, the ~4,300 cases in 2024, the ~¥35,000 street price and its decade-long rise, the ¥500,000 outlier and the share of fraud money moving by transfer. 4 nippon.com carrying Jiji Press, 16 October 2026, read at source, for the Cabinet's approval of the remote-access bill and its amendment of the Police Duties Execution Act; Jiji via AdnKronos for the panel's 24 September recommendation and its chair. **The bill had not been voted on when this issue closed.** 5 A note.com analysis of the draft, read at source, for the quoted "necessary measures" language, the absence of any specified method, the reported panel remark and the Digital Agency breach dates. **Commentary by a named author, attributed as such, not reporting.** 6 **The Japan Federation of Bar Associations' own opinion of 17 April 2025, read at source**, for its three conditions. **It addresses the 2025 amendment, not the 2026 bill, on which the federation has published nothing; the comparison is this desk's. Under-radar check: no feature on tokuryū as a phenomenon was found from the New York Times, BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times, The Economist, Bloomberg, AP or the Guardian. Asahi's and Yomiuri's own sites refused this desk.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

What the number was counting

Today's book kept running into the same fault. Singapore's exports rose **68.4 per cent** in September, and the agency that published it says the headline is mostly **S$3.7bn** of boat hulls (p5). American housing starts fell **5.2 per cent** inside an error band of **11.8**, and the dollar moved on it anyway (p14). Gold is being called a record while sitting **8.1 per cent below its own second-quarter average**. A wage guideline reached its widest band since 2021 in the year barely a quarter of employers met it.

Words do it too. London calls a mission defensive and, four paragraphs down the same release, extends refuelling for the offensive one (p3). A hanger sold under a famous name was made by a company whose name is on nothing (p6). An eighty-billion-dollar loss turns out to be, for the most part, a company becoming more valuable (p7). And a screen-time review of **2.8 million** children found its largest effect on schoolwork and **nothing at all** on attention — which is the opposite of the argument being had about it (p12).

The sharpest case closes the book. Japan arrested **2,307** people for special fraud last year and **66** of them were giving the orders — **2.9 per cent** (p21). The arrest figure is real, large, and rising. It is also counting the wrong people, and the state has noticed: it is now rewriting three statutes so it can forge papers, sell bank accounts and open a phone before anything happens. A measurement you cannot act on eventually changes what the measurer is willing to become.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the UK Ministry of Defence's own operational update; EnterpriseSG's September trade report, downloaded as a PDF because the agency's own listing page has returned an error for four issues; the Ministry of Manpower's release and the full NWC guidelines; Singapore's own real-time air-quality feeds; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' CPI release and the Census Bureau's construction PDF; the Federal Reserve's own open-market page and the Treasury's daily par-yield file; the World Gold Council's quarterly demand report; MOFCOM's Announcement No. 48 and its spokesperson Q&A; Nvidia's newsroom; Recursive's model cards and the Ollama and llama.cpp release pages; Apple's Singapore store; Esoteric's and Technics' own press releases; Box Office Mojo, Metacritic, Rotten Tomatoes and Oricon's own chart page; *JAMA Pediatrics*, the MOH expert panel's PDF, *Nature Communications* via Europe PMC and three sports-medicine abstracts; the makers' and retailers' own product and checkout pages for every hanger and bench price; Japan's National Police Agency organised-crime report, read as extracted PDF text. **Hosts that refused this desk, and are therefore quoted nowhere in this issue: Reuters, the BBC, the Associated Press, the Guardian, Sky News, CNBC, The Verge, Wired, Billboard, Variety, Deadline, Channel NewsAsia, SETHLUI, Time Out Singapore, Ticketmaster Singapore, eBay, and eight of the retrocomputing forums named on p15–p17. Reddit refused for the eighth consecutive issue. Where a figure could not be read at its own publisher it is flagged in the desk's own sources line; where it could not be verified at all it was held or dropped rather than printed.**